



Catechesim Guide Book III
The Church of the Virgin Mary
and St. Athanasius

*John 1:10-13- “He was in the world,
and the world was made through Him,
and the world did not know Him.*

*He came to His own, ‘ and His own
did not receive Him. But as many as
received Him, to them He gave the right to
be-come children of God, to those who
believe in His name:,who were born,
not of blood, nor of the will of the flesh,
nor of the will of man, but of God.”*

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***The Church of the Virgin Mary & St. Athanasius
Catechism Guide Book II
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"Coptic Church"...On one hand, its theology is based on nothing outside the scriptures. On the other hand, the doctrines agree in all parts with those of the Early Church i.e. the tradition which has the proper interpretation and application of the teachings of our Lord and the Apostles as understood and practiced by the Christians and the leaders of the Church during the period of the One Universal Church until the division of 451 A.D." Bishop Athanasius of Ben-Swef and Bahnassa (1977)".

The Coptic Church was established in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ by St. Mark the Evangelist in the city of Alexandria around 43 A.D. The church adheres to the Nicene Creed. St. Athanasius (296-373 A.D.), the twentieth Pope of the Coptic Church effectively defended the Doctrine of the Lord Jesus Christ's Divinity at the Council of Nicea in 325 A.D. His affirmation of the doctrine earned him the title; "Father of Orthodoxy" and St. Athanasius "the Apostolic".

The term "Coptic" is derived from the Greek "Aigyptos" meaning "Egyptian". When the Arabs arrived in Egypt in the seventh century, they called the Egyptians "qibt". Thus the Arabic word "qibt" came to mean both "Egyptians" and "Christians".

The term "Orthodoxy" here refers to the preservation of the "Original Faith" by the Copts who, throughout the ages, defended the Old Creed against the numerous attacks aimed at it.

The Coptic Orthodox Church believes that the Holy Trinity: God The Father, God The Son, and God The Holy Spirit, are equal to each other in one unity; and that the Lord Jesus Christ is the only Savior of the world. Less changes have taken place in the Coptic Church than in any other church whether in the ritual or doctrine aspects and that the succession of the Coptic Patriarchs, Bishops, priests and Deacons has been continuous.

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Introduction

"Blessed is Egypt my people" (Isa 19:25)

God's promise to His people is always fulfilled; He foretold that He would ride on a light and upon a swift cloud and come to Egypt (Isa 19:1); and in that day there will be an altar to the Lord in the midst of the land of Egypt, and a pillar to the Lord at its border (Isa 19:19). This promise was fulfilled by the flight of the Holy Family from the face of the tyrant Herod to find refuge among the Gentiles. Thus our Lord Jesus Christ came during His childhood to Egypt to lay by Himself the foundation stone of His Church in Egypt which has become one of the four primary "Sees" in the world, among the churches of Jerusalem, Antioch and Rome, and joined later by the "See" of Constantinople.

The star of the Egyptian Church shone through the School of Alexandria which taught Christendom the allegoric and spiritual methods in interpreting the Holy Scripture and was the leader in defending the Orthodox faith on an ecumenical level.

The Christian monastic movement in all its forms started in Egypt, attracting the heart of the Church towards the desert, to practice the angelic inner life. This happened at the time when the doors of the royal court had been opened to the clergy, and this consequently endangered the church, as the quiet and spiritual church work was mixed with the temporal authority and politics of the royal court.

number of martyrs and confessors throughout ages. Sometimes the people of towns were martyred and many struggled to win the crowns of martyrdom happily and with a heart full of JOY-

Our Church is ancient and new at the same time: ancient in being apostolic, founded by St. Mark the Evangelist and traditional in holding fast to the original apostolic faith without deviation. She is also new through her Living Messiah who never becomes old and through the Spirit of God who renews her youth (Ps. 103:5).

The Coptic Church is rich with her evangelistic and ascetic life, her genuine patriotic inheritance, her heavenly worship, her spiritual rituals, her effective and living hymns, her beautiful icons, etc. She attracts the heart towards heaven without ignoring actual daily life. We can say that she without deviation. One finds in her life, sweetness and power of Spirit, with appreciation to and sanctification of arts, literature and human culture.

The Church is well known for her numerous saints: ascetics, clergymen and laymen. She offered many saints throughout ages and is still offering the same today. For she believes that practicing the sanctified life and communion with God, the Holy One, is prior to satisfying minds with solid mental studies.

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The Martyrdom of Coptic Christians in Egypt:



The historians call our Church "The Church of Martyrs," not only because of the numerous numbers of martyrs in our Church, but also because of the ardent desire that her members had shown for martyrdom. The waves of persecutions in Egypt began from the first century, when the Apostle St. Mark was martyred

pagan Rome became the greatest enemy to the new Christian faith. They fought with all its might to destroy Christianity. Diocletian believed he could more easily annihilate Christianity in the whole empire. In all, about 800,000 Christians were put to the sword in Egypt.

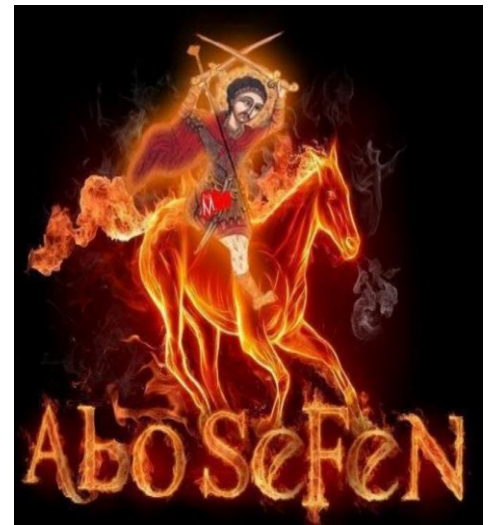
It is worthy to note that the persecution inaugurated by Diocletian was sustained by Maximinus Daza (305-313), Caesar of Egypt and Syria, whose reign was the most prolific in bloodshed of any period in the whole history of the church persecutions.



St. Theodore



St. George



St Abanoub



St. Mari Mina



St. Anba Wannas

THE LEGACY OF THE COPTIC ORTHODOX CHURCH

By

Victor Beshir

Come and discover

A spiritual Christian treasure that was founded in Egypt 2000 years ago, prophesized about in the Bible, blessed by the Lord Jesus Christ in His visit to Egypt, and now transferred to thousands of locations around the globe.

The Coptic Orthodox Church was founded in 56 AD by St. Mark, the writer of the second Gospel of the New Testament. He was one of the apostles who lived with Christ for over three years. He walked with Jesus, conversed with Him about theological issues, listened to His public sermons and His private teaching to His disciples, witnessed His miracles, and learned from Him how to worship and how to walk down the divine path that leads to a fulfilling spiritual life.

St. Mark arrived in Alexandria, Egypt, approximately 23 years after the crucifixion of Jesus. There, he met people who were eagerly waiting for a heavenly message. They were longing to find a faith that encompasses the full truth, which satisfies their search for God, and answers the ever-lasting questions that man has asked about God, the universe, life, death, evil, and good.

St. Mark preached Christianity in its full truth of the One Living God whose Son was incarnated to reveal that He is the only truth, life, and path that man needs to know in order to have peace of mind, joy in heart, and a fulfilling life. St. Mark then established the first Christian theological school in the world. This profound historically known as the "The Theological School of Alexandria," or the "Catechetical School of Alexandria" while guarding the original Christian dogma, served as the founder of Christian theology. The teaching of this school reconciled faith with philosophy cadence, and materialistic matters with sublimed spiritual ones. It was also famous for spirituality of its professors, and students alike. Since it became a haven for truth and life, it attracted students from all over the world, who came to quench their thirst from its spirituality and full-truth teaching. Many of these students became the leaders of the Christian World at that time.

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*The legacy of the Coptic Orthodox Church is based upon keeping the original faith and beliefs as taught by Jesus Christ, received by the apostles, and delivered to the members of the Coptic Church by St. Mark the apostle, without alteration until this day. The Coptic Church believes that the church should be obedient to what the Lord has established and must not be an initiator of altering beliefs. It must be a keeper" for the faith which was once for all delivered to the saints." **(Jude 1:3).***

Moreover, St. Mark trained people on how to worship and how to gain a fulfilling spiritual life. This deep spirituality remains until the present time, as a uniquely amazing characteristic of the Coptic Church. It dramatically changed peoples lives then, and it still continues to inflame peoples' spiritual lives. In the fourth century, this sparkling spirituality in Egypt lead to the start of 'Monasticism,' a life style that seeks celibacy and life dedication to God.

Tens of thousands of men and women followed the example of the Egyptian pioneer: St. Anthony the Great, the first Christian monk in the world. The spiritual lives of his follower monks, nuns, and hermits historically known as the Desert Fathers attracted a great number of Christians from all over the world.

They came to visit or to live in the Egyptian desert, to learn from the Copts about the path to higher levels of spirituality. Some of them returned to their homeland and established monastic lives in their own countries, and this was the start of a great monastic movement that spread all over the world, especially in Europe. Others, like Cassian and Palladius, wrote books about what they had witnessed in the Egyptian monasteries. A visitor described the Coptic monasteries as, "heaven on earth," and described hermits as, "heavenly human beings or earthly angels."

The Desert Fathers left behind a well established spiritual path that leads to the highest level a person may reach. They kept for the church, until today, a peaceful, joyful, safe, and fulfilling Christian spirituality that has no other match, because its roots go back to its founder Jesus Christ, the only source of divine spirituality. So, the second aspects of the legacy of the Coptic Orthodox Church is its deep spirituality that lived gracefully by Christ himself and His disciples, delivered fully to the Coptic Church by St. Mark, kept faithfully by its members in all ages, and practiced heavily by its monks, nuns, and hermits.

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*"There will be an altar to the Lord in the midst of the land of Egypt, and a pillar and a pillar to the Lord at its border (**Isaiah 19:19**)*

This is the only prophecy in the Bible about a future church with a Christian altar.

This future church, the Coptic Church, was blessed once again by the only visit that Jesus, Virgin Mary, and Joseph made to another country. The Coptic Orthodox Church has captured the full light that shined over the world. 2000 years ago by Jesus Christ, the incarnate God. It lived faithfully to its enlightenment, and kept the torch of spirituality burning until this day. So, the third aspect of the legacy of the Coptic Orthodox Church is based on a biblical prophecy that refers to the Coptic Church as an altar and a pillar to the Lord. Also, the Coptic Orthodox Church is a biblical church that considers the Bible as its first and foremost theological and spiritual source.

+ + +

Among more than 20,000 Christian sects and denominations exist today the Coptic Orthodox Church along with very few other Orthodox Churches can faithfully claim that it kept the original teachings of Christianity, from its inception until this day without changes. However, in regards to spirituality, it stands out with its own unique spirituality that is strongly felt in its current liturgies, prayers, and worship. Its practical faith was once put to test in the tenth century. Faced by either genocide or moving of a mountain near Cairo, Egypt, the Coptic Church fasted and prayed for three days, and was able afterwards to move the Mountain of Al-Mukattam. Therefore, it is the church that has the faith to move the mountains. So, the fourth aspect of the legacy of the Coptic Orthodox Church is its practical, strong faith that once moved the mountain, a faith that no other church can claim.

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Here, is a church that is as old as Christianity itself. Everything it believes in or it practices has been accurately delivered to it from one generation to the next. It is the historical church that Jesus has left behind; it did not diminish over the centuries, nor did it change. Its claim of keeping the original faith has its own evidence, the blood of millions of its own individuals who preferred to be slain than to deny Christ or even to accept a false teaching or a teaching that is different from what they have received from their ancestors. The fifth aspect of the legacy of the Coptic Orthodox Church is based on the fact that it paid a high price to keep the faith pure and without changes; the blood of millions of its martyrs.

Holy Tradition in the Old Testament:

(Heb 11:1-29; 1 Pet 3:1-6) God emphasized the role of Holy Tradition as He commanded the fathers to hand over **verbally** the teachings and stories they knew to their children **(Ex 13:14-16; Deut 4:9)**. This is also evident from the words of King David, "We have heard with our ears, O God, our fathers have told us, what deeds You did in their days, in days of old." **(Ps 66:1)**

(Gen 28:17-18)

Our father Jacob called the place where he saw his dream '*the house of God*'. He also took a stone, set it up as a pillar and poured oil on it. How was he familiar with the term '*house of God*' and how did he know about the consecration of the houses of God by pouring oil? Again, only the existence of Holy Tradition explains this.

• (Gen 39:7-10)

Joseph the Righteous knew that adultery was '*a great wickedness*' through Holy Tradition long before Moses the Prophet wrote the seventh commandment

Holy Tradition in the New Testament:

to teach the whole world and to make disciples of all nations, "Go therefore and make disciples of all nations." **(Mt 28:19)** Our Lord Jesus Christ did not write a book, He did not document His blessed teachings on paper, but He chose His disciples who accompanied Him day and night. They absorbed His teachings and learned directly from Him. He sent them

• St. Paul also said to his disciple Timothy, "The things which you have **heard from me** among many witnesses, commit these to faithful men who will be able to teach others also." **(2Tim 2:2)**

• St. Paul also said to his disciple Timothy, "The things which you have **heard from me** among many witnesses, commit these to faithful men who will be able to teach others also." **(2Tim 2:2)**

. St. John said, "And there are also many other things that Jesus did, which if they were written one by one, I suppose that even the world itself could not contain the books that would be written." **(Jn 21:25)**

Christianity is, therefore, a religion that is Tradition-bound and is strongly committed to discipleship.



11ne Orthodox Creed (Nicene Creed)

Christian Orthodox Faith: Dogma

Dogma is what is believed, taught, confessed and practiced. Dogmas, to the Coptic Orthodox Church, are not merely theological concepts concerning God, man, the Church, eternal life, heavenly creatures, demons, and other such matters, which are to be discussed among clergymen, scholars and laymen. Rather, they are, in essence, daily experiences which each member of the Church should live. In other words, dogmas representing our faith in God have one message, namely, our communion with God the Father in Jesus Christ, the Incarnate Word of God, by His Holy Spirit.



St. Athanasius of Alexandria, the author of the Orthodox Creed of Faith (Athanasios Alexandrias; c. 296–298 – 2 May 373), also called **Athanasius the Great**, **Athanasius the Confessor** or, primarily in the Coptic Orthodox Church, **Athanasius the Apostolic**, was the twentieth Patriarch of the Coptic Church

The Orthodox Creed



Truly we believe in One God, God the Father, the Almighty, creator of Heaven and earth and of all things visible and invisible.

We believe in one Lord, Jesus Christ, the only begotten Son of God, born of the Father before all ages. Light of Light; True God of True God; begotten, not made; consubstantial with the Father, by whom all things were made. Who for us and for our salvation descended from Heaven, and was incarnate of the Holy Spirit and of the Virgin Mary, and became man. He was crucified for us during the reign of Pontius Pilate. He suffered and was buried. He arose from the dead on the third day, according to the Scriptures. He ascended to the heavens, and sits at the right hand of His Father. He will come back in His glory to judge the living and the dead; and His Kingdom shall have no end.

Truly we believe in the Holy Spirit, the Life—Giving Lord, who proceeds from the Father; we worship and glorify Him together with the Father and the Son, Who speaks through the prophets. We believe in one Holy, Universal and Apostolic Church, and we acknowledge one baptism for the remission of sins. We await the resurrection of the dead, and the life of the world to come.

Amen

<http://www.Coptic.net/prayers/Creed.txt>





Explanation of the Orthodox Creed

The essence of our religious convictions depends not on external experiences but on our acceptance of God-given truths. Surely one cannot prove truths of the spiritual world by any laboratory experiments. These truths belong to the sphere of personal religious experience. The more a We begin the Creed with “We believe.” This is because person grows in the spiritual life – the more one prays, thinks about God, does good – the more his inner spiritual experience develops, the clearer the religious truths become to him. In this fashion, faith becomes for him a subject of personal experience. We believe that God is one fullness of perfection; we believe that He is a perfect spirit, timeless, without beginning, all-powerful and all-wise. God is everywhere, sees all, and knows beforehand when something will happen. He is good beyond measure, just and all-holy. He needs nothing and is the reason for everything that exists.

We believe that God is one in Essence and Trinity in Persons (i.e., the one true God has appeared to us as Father, Son, and Holy Spirit). The Father, Son, and Holy Spirit is the Trinity, one in Essence and indivisible. The Father is not born and does not proceed from the others. The Son pre-eternally was born of the Father, and the Holy Spirit eternally proceeds from the Father

We believe that all the Persons of the Holy Trinity are equally in divine perfection, greatness, power, and glory. That is, we believe that the Father is true and perfect God, the Son is true and perfect God, and, the Holy Spirit is true and perfect God. Therefore, in prayers, we simultaneously glorify the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit as one God.

We believe that the entire visible and invisible world was created by God. In the beginning God created the invisible, great angelic world, otherwise known as Heaven. As stated in the Bible, God created our material or physical world from nothing. This was not done at once, but gradually during periods of time which in the Bible are called “days.” God created the world not out of necessity or need but out of His all-good desire to do so in order that His other creations might enjoy life. Being Himself endlessly good, God created all things good. Evil appeared in the world from the misuse of free will, with which God has endowed both angels and people. For example, the Devil (Satan) and his demons were at one time angels of God. But they rebelled against their Creator and became demons. They were cast out of Heaven and formed their own kingdom called “hell.” From that moment on, they tempted people to sin and became our enemies and the enemies of our salvation

We believe that all things are under God’s control; that is, he provides for every creature and guides everything to a good goal. God loves and looks after us as a mother looks after her child. For this reason nothing bad can befall a person who trusts in God.

We believe that the Son of God, our Lord Jesus Christ, came down from heaven for our salvation. He came to earth and took on our flesh by the Holy Spirit and the Virgin Mary. Being God from all eternity, He in the time of King Herod took on our human nature, both soul and body, and is therefore truly God and truly man, or the God-man. In one divine Person He combined two natures, divine and human. These two natures will remain with Him always without change, neither blending nor changing from one into the other.

We believe that our Lord Jesus Christ, while living on earth, enlightened the world by His teaching, His example, and miracles. He taught people what they should believe and how they should live so that they may inherit eternal life. By His prayers to His Father, His complete obedience to the Father's Will, His sufferings and death, He defeated the devil and redeemed the world from sin and death. By His Resurrection from the dead, He laid the foundation for our resurrection. After His Ascension in the flesh to Heaven, which took place forty days after His Resurrection from the dead, our Lord Jesus Christ sat at the right hand of God the Father; that is to say, He received equal power with God the Father and since then together with Him governs the face of the world.

We believe that the Holy Spirit, proceeding from God the Father from the beginning of the world, together with the Father and the Son gives existence to all creation, gives life, and governs all. He is the source of a grace-filled spiritual life, both for angels as well as people, and equally with the Father and the Son is worthy of all glory and worship. The Holy Spirit in the Old Testament spoke through the prophets. Then in the beginning of the New Testament, He spoke through the Apostles and now lives in the Church of Christ, guiding her pastors and people in the truth.

We believe that our Lord Jesus Christ founded the Church on earth for the salvation of all who believe in Him. He sent the Holy Spirit to the Apostles on Pentecost. Since that time the Holy Spirit abides in the Church, that grace-filled community or union of believing Orthodox Christians, and preserves her in the purity of Christ's teaching. The grace of the Holy Spirit abides in the Church, cleanses those who repent of sins, helps the believers grow in good deeds, and sanctifies them.

We believe that the Church is One, Holy, Catholic and Apostolic. She is One because all Orthodox Christians, although belonging to different national, local churches, are one family together with the angels and saints in Heaven. The oneness of the Church depends on oneness of Faith and Grace.

The Church is Holy because her faithful children are sanctified by the word of God, prayer, and the Sacraments. The Church is Catholic because what we believe is the same teaching held to be true by all Orthodox Christians, always and everywhere. The Church is called Apostolic because it preserves Apostolic teaching and the Apostolic succession. From ancient times, this Apostolic succession passes on without interruption from Bishop to Bishop in the sacrament of Ordination. The Church will remain of our Lord and Savior until the end of time.

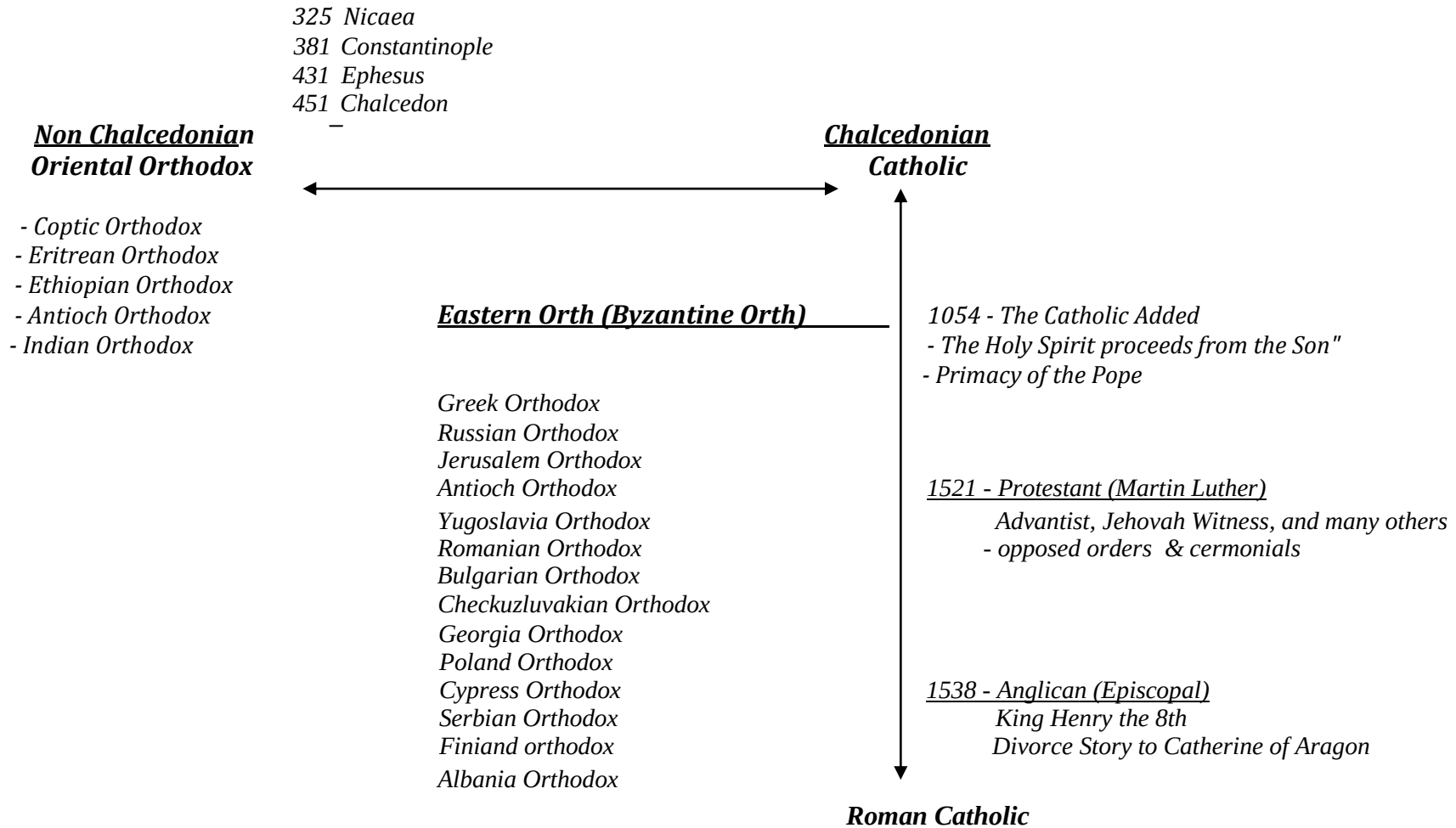
We believe that in the sacrament of Baptism the believer is forgiven all sins. The believer becomes a member of the Church. Access to the other sacraments of salvation becomes available to him at this time. In the sacrament of Chrismation the believer receives the grace of the Holy Spirit. In Confession or Repentance, sins are forgiven. In Holy Communion, offered at the Divine Liturgy, the believer receives the very Body and Blood of Christ. In the sacrament of Matrimony, an inseparable union is created between a man and a woman. In the sacrament of Ordination Deacons, Priests, and Bishops are ordained to serve the Church. In Holy Unction, the healing of physical and spiritual illness is offered.

We believe that before the end of the world Jesus Christ, accompanied by angels, will again come to the earth in glory. Every person, according to His Word, will resurrect from the dead. A miracle will occur in which the souls of people who have died will return into the bodies which they possessed during their earthly life. All the dead will come to life. During the General Resurrection, the bodies of the saints, both those resurrecting and those still living will be renewed and become spiritualized in the image of the Resurrected Body of Christ. After the resurrection, everyone will appear before the Judgment of Christ, to receive what he is due, according to what he has done when he lived in his body, good or evil. After the Judgment, unrepentant sinners will enter into eternal torments and the righteous into eternal life. This will begin the Kingdom of Christ, which will have no end. With the one word "Amen" we witness to the fact that we accept and acknowledge with our whole heart this Creed which we confess to be true.

The Creed is read by a Catechumen (one about to receive Baptism) during the Mystery of Baptism. During the Baptism of an infant, the Creed is read by the Sponsor. The Creed is sung at the Liturgy and should be read daily at Morning Prayers. An attentive reading of the Creed greatly strengthens our faith. This happens because the Creed is not just a formal statement of belief but a prayer. When we say "I believe" in a spirit of prayer, along with the other words of the Creed, we enliven and strengthen our Faith in God and in all those truths which are contained in the Creed. This is why it is so important for the Orthodox Christian to recite the Creed daily or at least regularly.

History of the Church

One Church

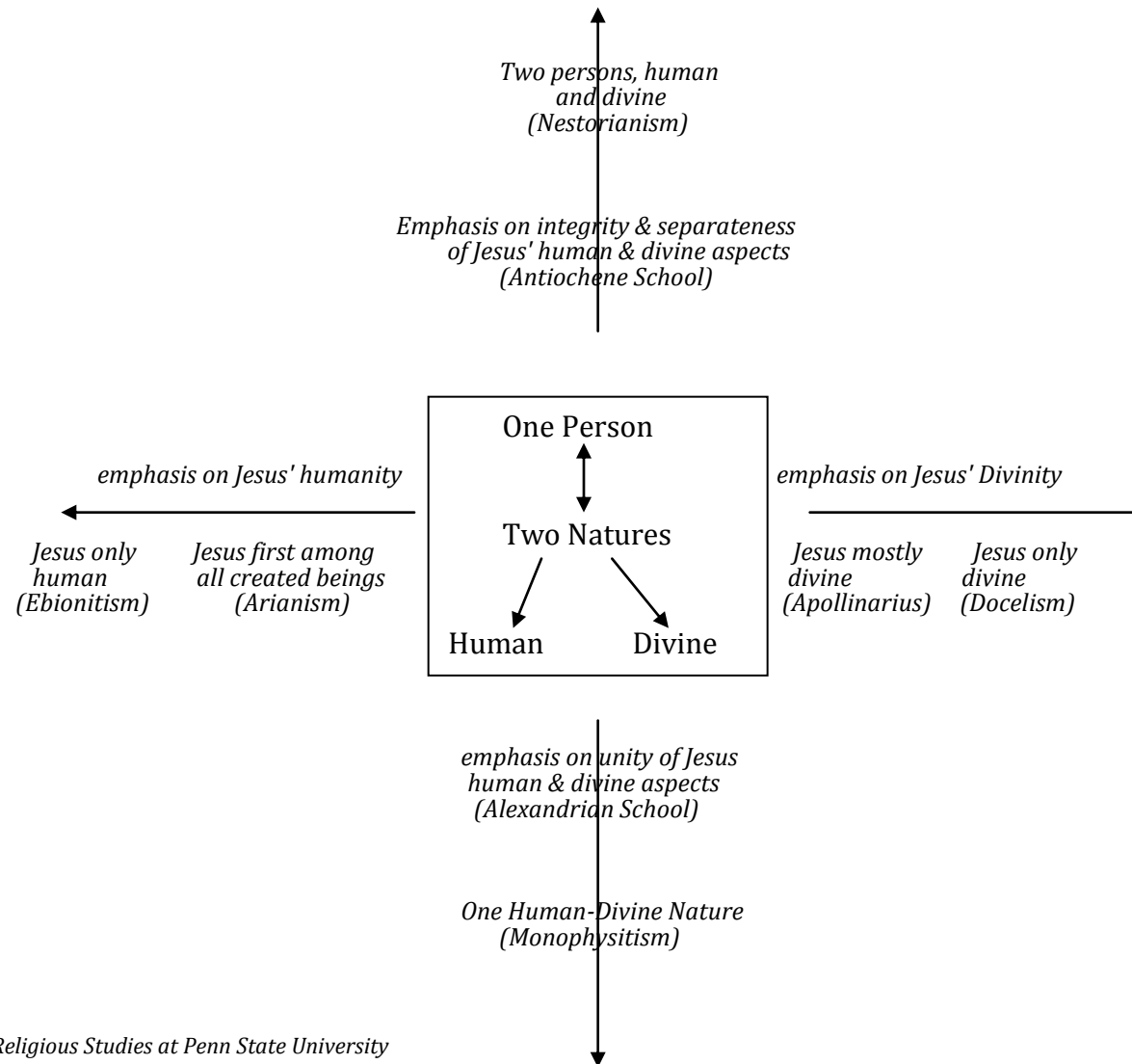


courtesy of Mr. Ashraf Gabour of Boston, MA June 20, 2007 - An overview of the Coptic Church K.K. Bros

History of the Coptic Church



Council of Chalcedon 451 AD:



Ref: Philip Jenkins, Professor of History and Religious Studies at Penn State University

Let Us make man in Our image, according to Our likeness.” (Gen 1:26)

+Lecture VII: The Triunity of God +

Introduction:

Q. What do we believe of the mystery of Trinity in Unity?

A. Firstly, we believe in the one Eternal and Everlasting God, the one only perfect Being. Secondly, that He is one Being in three Persons. Thirdly, that He alone is the Creator of all things and the Governor of the universe.

Q. What is meant by "the only perfect Being"?

A. This means that He alone possesses the personal perfections which no one shares with Him. He is the self-existing, the only One holy in His person and attributes, most good and benevolent, Almighty and all-powerful, supreme in wisdom and knowing all things, the One Whose will is done and Whose glory, majesty, and sovereignty are supreme, the One distinguished above all others, the Pure One, the Incomprehensible One, the One near to all and ever present, the Author of every existing thing.

Q. What is meant by His being "One Being in three persons"?

A. That He is One Being of one substance, but of Three persons, the Father, the Son and the Holy Ghost.

Q. Are the Persons equal in perfection?

A. Yes; equal in eternity, in self-existence, in holiness, in glory, in goodness, in wisdom, in will, in power, in immortality, and in all perfect attributes; for their substance is one, their divinity is one, and their sovereignty is one.

One day St. Augustine was walking on the sandy beach by the sea. There churned in his mind the mystery of the Holy Trinity. He was talking to himself, "One God, but Three Persons. Three Persons—not three gods but One God. What does it mean? How can it be explained? How can my mind take it in And so he was tormenting his mind and beating his brain, when he saw a little boy on the beach. He approached him to see what he was doing. The child had dug a small hole in the sand. With his little hands he was carrying water from the sea and was dumping it in the little hole. St. Augustine asked, "What are you doing, my child?" The child replied, "I want to put all the water of the sea into this hole." Once more St. Augustine asked, "But is it possible for all the water of this great sea to be contained in this little hole?" And the child asked him in return, "If the water of the finite sea cannot be contained in this little hole, then how can The Infinite Triune God be contained in your mind?" And the child disappeared; he was actually an angel!

The doctrine of The Holy Trinity is not merely an “article of faith” which men are called to “believe.” It is not simply a dogma, which the Church requires its members to “accept in faith.” Neither is the doctrine of The Holy Trinity the invention of scholars and the result of intellectual speculation or philosophical thinking. The doctrine of the Holy Trinity arises from God’s Own revelation about Himself; God being God, all our knowledge of Him comes by divine revelation, for it is impossible for us to know God without His willingness to be known. God is known only as He makes Himself known to us through the revealing and saving agency of His Word and Spirit.

God revealed Himself through Himself, through the incarnation of His Son among us as our Saviour and by the power of His Spirit. The Christian doctrine of God is thus inescapably and essentially Chr1'st0centr'c, for it pivots upon God’s self-revelation and self-communication in the incarnation, in an objective manifestation, an imprint of the divine Hypostasis, which is identical with the very Being of God Himself. This does not mean that all our knowledge of God can be reduced to Christology, but that, as there is only one Mediator between God and man, who is Himself both God and Man, and only one revelation of God in which He Himself is its actual content, all authentic knowledge of God is derived and understood in accordance with the incarnate reality of God’s self-revelation in Lord Jesus Christ, and is formulated in doctrinal coherence with Christology. This is to say that doctrinal statements about God are possible and true only when Christologically grounded, for only in Lord Jesus Christ do we really have to do with an objective personal self-revelation of God which bridges the distance between God and us and which is identical with the very Being of God Himself. It is with the same force that our knowledge and worshipping of God include the Holy Spirit. As He sends through the Son to dwell with us and open our mind toward Himself beyond ourselves, and thus to complete the circle of God's own self revelation and self imparting movement in us whereby He enables us to respond to Him in faith and understanding, the Holy Spirit is no less divine than the Son. How could the Spirit pour the love of God into our Hearts, how could the Spirit mediate Lord Jesus Christ to us, and how could our Lord Jesus be present to us in the Spirit, if the Spirit How could the Spirit pour the love of God into our hearts, how could the Spirit mediate Lord Jesus if the Spirit were not Himself divine like the Father and the Son and of one and the same Being (Homoousios) with them? Like the Son of God the Holy spirit is no mere cosmic power intermediate between God and the world, but is the very Spirit of God who eternally dwells in Him and in whom God knows Himself, so that for us to know God in His Spirit is to know Him in the hidden depths of His Triune Being as Holy Spirit as well as Father and Son.

Apart from the communion of the Holy Spirit we could not enjoy the Grace of the Lord Jesus Christ and the love of God the Father. Only because God has actually made Himself known to us can we speak of Him in this way. This self-revelation of God to us as Father, Son and Holy Spirit provides for us the immediate ground in human existence and history where God may be known as He is in His Triune Reality. The immediate ground on which we actually know God in His historical self—revelation is one and the same with the ultimate ground that God Himself eternally is, for in Lord Jesus Christ and in the Holy Spirit God is wholly identical with the content of His self-revelation and self-communication.

God reveals Himself through Himself, and what God communicates to us is not something of Himself but His very Self, true God from true God. In Him the Revealer and the Revealed, the Giver and the Gift are of one and the same Being. In Lord Jesus Christ God has revealed Himself and given Himself to us unreservedly in the fullness of His divine Reality, in such a way that what He reveals and gives us is grounded in His ultimate Being as God.

That is the central truth, the Deity of Lord Jesus Christ, upon which the Christian conception of God and of His saving activity depends, as the great theologians and councils made clear once for all in the fourth century in their formulation of the crucial concept of the homoousion applied to the Son and the Spirit as the key truth they had to maintain against threats to the Gospel from every side. At this point, it is appropriate to introduce the terms 'immanent or theological Trinity' 'economic Trinity'.

The first term refers to our conceptions of God in His eternal Being and the second refers to our conceptions of God that arise out of the economy of God's saving revelation in history. In the Gospel God does not just appear to us as Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, for He really is Father, Son, and Holy Spirit in Himself, and reveals Himself as such. Therefore, the economic Trinity and theological Trinity are not to be separated from one another for they are locked together in God's threefold self-revelation and self-communication to us as Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. While for St. Athanasius economy and theology must be clearly distinguished, they are not to be separated from each other. If the economic Trinity and the theological Trinity were disparate, this would bring into question whether God Himself was the actual content of His revelation, and whether God Himself was really Lord Jesus Christ reconciling the world to Himself.

That is the significance of the term homoousion ('consubstantial', of one substance, or of one and the same Being with the Father) formulated by the council of Nicea in 325 AD. If there is no real bond in God between the economic Trinity and the theological Trinity, the saving events proclaimed in the economy of the Gospel would be without any divine validity and the doctrine of the Trinity would be lacking any ultimate divine truth. The Trinitarian message of the Gospel tell us that the very contrary is the case, for in Lord Jesus Christ and in the Holy Spirit we really have to do with the Lord God Himself as our Saviour.

When we look into the Trinitarian content of this self-revelation of God as Father, Son and Holy Spirit, One Being (Ousia), Three Persons (Hypostasis) we become even more aware of its intrinsically unique and exclusive nature, for to believe in God as a Trinity in His eternal Being, means renouncing every form of Unitarianism as well as of polytheism. In fact to conceive of God as Unity and Trinity, Trinity and Unity, is the most exclusive of all possible conceptions of God, not only because there is no humanly explicable way of thinking of the Three as One and the One as Three, but because of the unique Nature of God who is Father, Son, and Holy Spirit in His one eternal Being. However, we may and surely must say that the Three Persons are integrated in the One Being and the One Being is integrated in the Three Divine Persons, such that there is no One Being apart from the Three Persons, and there are no Three divine Persons apart from the One Being.

The Holy Trinity is a Unity and the Unity is a Trinity, for God is Triune in Himself and it is essentially in a triune way that God makes Himself known to us. In our knowing of the Triunity of God, we are engaged in a kind of knowing in which we move from the 'whole' to the 'parts', and from the 'parts' to the 'whole', understanding the 'parts' in the light of the 'whole' and the 'whole' in the light of the 'parts'.

This way of speaking of the 'whole' and 'parts', however, is not strictly appropriate to God's Triune self-revelation as Unity and Trinity and Trinity and Unity, for the three divine Persons may not be thought of as 'parts' of the Trinity nor may the Trinity be thought of as a 'whole' composed of parts'. Neither is it appropriate to our apprehension of the Holy Trinity, although it may be more appropriate when we are speaking of the 'doctrine' of the Trinity as a whole and the distinct doctrines' of the Father, of the son, and of the Holy Spirit.

It must also be pointed out, however, that while the Triune God reveals Himself as a whole and while it is as a whole that God is the object of our knowing, this does not mean that we can know Him wholly or have a comprehensive knowledge of Him, for in His transcendent wholeness, God eludes our comprehension.

What God does allow us to apprehend of Himself breaks through the narrow confines of our grasp, so that in the very act of apprehending something of Him we know that we are incapable of comprehending Him. Even in His condescension to reveal Himself to us God infinitely exceeds what we can grasp or conceive, so that our knowledge of the whole God cannot but be 'in part' or 'partial' as St. Paul said, "Now I know in part, but then I shall know just as I also am known. (1 Cor 13:12)

All this means that in a faithful account of the doctrine of the Holy Trinity our thoughts cannot but engage in a deep circular movement from Unity to Trinity and from Trinity to Unity, for we are unable to speak of the whole Trinity without already speaking of the three particular Persons of the Trinity or to speak of any of the three Persons without presuming knowledge of the whole Triunity, for God is only God as He is Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. It was said above, with some reservation, that in our knowing of the Triunity of God we engage in a kind of knowing in which we move from the 'whole' to the 'parts' and from the 'parts' to the 'whole'. The reason for the reservation is due to the fact that the Oneness of the Holy Trinity is a three-in-oneness, that is, a wholeness which includes the three divine Persons such that each divine Person is Himself whole God, so that the usual way of thinking in terms of the whole and the parts does not apply. As St. Gregory Nazianzen said, "No sooner do I place before the mind the One, than I am surrounded by the splendor of the Three.

No sooner do I distinguish the Three, than I am brought back to the One. When any one of the Three appears to me I think of Him as a whole; my eyes are filled and the greater part escapes my eye. I cannot comprehend the magnitude of the One, so as to impart a greater greatness to the Rest. When, again, I consider the Three together, I perceive but one splendor, and I cannot divide or measure the light that is one. " (Oration XL. In sanctum baptisma, 41, PG 36:417C.)

The fathers and theologians of the Early Church reflected upon the fact that, since the proof of an unknown reality is its own evidence and the conceptual assent or basic belief it calls forth from people, the right way for people to break through into a completely new realm of meaning or truth is the way of faith—hence the principle widely promulgated in the Church: Unless you believe you will not understand. This is certainly the case whenever we have to do with ultimate which carry their own authority calling for the intelligent commitment of belief, and provide the irreducible ground upon which rational knowledge and theological formulation take place.

** This lecture is adapted from The Christian Doctrine of God' One Being Three Persons by T. F. Torrance*



“But who do you say that I am?” (Mt 16:15)

Lecture II: The Nature of Our Lord Jesus Christ

Our Faith Concerning Christology:

Our Lord Jesus Christ is God Himself, the Incarnate Logos, who took to Himself a complete manhood. His Divine Nature is united with His Human Nature in a complete Hypostatic (personal) Union without mingling, confusion, alteration or separation. Furthermore, the unity between the two Natures occurred without transmutation. Thus neither the Divine Nature transmutes to the Human Nature, nor did the Human Nature transmute to the Divine.

Without mingling as in the case of wheat and barley or salt and sugar. Without confusion as in the case of wine and water or tea and milk. Without alteration as in the case of chemical union: Carbon dioxide consists of Carbon and Oxygen, and the nature of both changes when they are combined; each loses some of its properties that distinguished it before this unity. In contrast, no change occurred to the Divine or Human Nature as a result of their unity. Without separation for His Divinity parted not from His Humanity for a single moment nor a twinkling of an eye.

The Divine Logos was united with the Human Nature (body & spirit) that He took from Virgin Mary by the action of the Holy Spirit: The Holy Spirit purified and sanctified the Virgin so that the Child to whom she gave birth would not inherit the original sin. This unity between the Two Natures (Human & Divine) took place from the first moment of the Holy Pregnancy. As a result of this unity between both Natures (Divine & Human) inside the Virgin's womb, One Nature (entity) was formed out of both: “The ONE Nature of God, the Incarnate Logos.” The Term “One Nature” does not refer to either of the Two Natures (Divine & Human), but it refers to the result of the union of Both Natures into this One Nature which is “the Nature of the Incarnate Logos”. The term “Two Natures” implies division or potential separation. Human language is inadequate when it comes to describing this union but here are two examples:

a) The union between Iron & Fire:

In the union of iron and fire, the iron is not changed into fire or the fire into iron. They are both united without mingling, confusion, or alteration.

{At a certain temperature the iron will change and extinguishing the fire will separate them}.

b) The union between the human spirit & body:

The nature of the human spirit unites with the physical earthly nature of the body without mingling, confusion, alteration, or transmutation {they will separate by death and then they reunite}. This union of the two natures (spirit & body) results in ONE nature that is the human nature. The term ONE here doesn't refer to either of the two natures (spirit — body) but it refers to the result of this union of BOTH natures into this ONE human being. Therefore, just as we say that the person is ONE nature consisting of two elements (spirit & body), we can also say about the Incarnate Logos that He is ONE entity of two natures (Divine & Human). The union of the spirit & body is a hypostatic one. So is the union of the Divine Logos & the Human Nature in the virgin's womb. A hypostatic, real, self-essential union not a mere connection that separates as Nestorius claimed. Although a person is formed of two natures (spirit & body), nobody refers to him/her as two. All the person's acts are attributed to this ONE nature, not to the spirit alone or the physical body alone. Similarly, all the acts of Christ should be attributed to Him as a whole, not to His Divine Nature independently or to His Human Nature independently.

These examples are intended to clarify some aspects of the union but they are not perfect, just like our human language. The imperfections are put between brackets.

+ **In a Nutshell:**

Our Lord Jesus Christ has Two Natures:

1. The Divine Nature of the LOGOS.
2. The Human Nature that He took from Virgin Mary.

The Human Nature is composed of Two+ Elements:

- a) Human Spirit.
- b) Human Body.

The Divine Nature of the LOGOS is united with every element of the Human Nature without mingling, confusion, alteration, transmutation, or separation. As a result of this Hypostatic Union, One Entity is formed out of Both (Divine & Human) Natures. This is the “One Nature Of God, The Incarnate Logos”. When we refer to this ONE NATURE we are referring to this ONE ENTITY that resulted from the union of BOTH the Divine and Human Natures. So what happened on the cross? Our Lord Jesus Christ died on the cross. Death means that His Human Spirit was separated from His Human Body. The Divine Logos remained united with BOTH the spirit and the body after their separation. Hence, His Divinity parted not from His Humanity. This explains why the body was not corrupted in the grave and it also explains how the spirit was able to return to the body when the Resurrection took place.

+ **Are we Monophysites?**

The Oriental Orthodox Churches (Coptic, Syrian, Armenian, Ethiopian, an Indian) are ‘Miaphysites’. There is a difference between the ‘Monophysites’ who believe in One Single Nature (Divine) of our Lord Jesus Christ and the ‘Miaphysites’ who believe in One United Nature or One Composite Nature (Divine & Human) of our Lord Jesus Christ. We do not believe in a Single Nature but we believe in One Incarnate Nature of the Logos.

+ **Our Faith concerning the One will and Act:**

Naturally, since we believe that after the union of the Divine and Human Natures, One Nature (entity) resulted, namely, the Nature of the Incarnate Logos, we also believe in One Will and One Act for the incarnate Logos. There is no contradiction or conflict between the will and the act of the Two Natures; what the Divine Nature chooses is undoubtedly chosen by the Human Nature. Our Lord Jesus Christ said, “My food is to do the will of Him who sent Me, and to finish His work” (Jn 4:34). This proves that His will is the same as the Father’s. Certainly, the Divine Logos has the same will as the Father since He is one with Him in the Godhead. Thus, it must be that the Nature of the Incarnate Logos has One Will that is not different from the Father. In fact, sin is nothing but a conflict between man’s will and God’s. But our Lord Jesus Christ said, “Which of you convicts Me of sin?” (Jn 8:46) proving His One will with the Father.

If there were no unity between the will of the Divine Logos and His Human Nature, internal conflict would have resulted. Far be it from Him! How then could the Lord Jesus Christ be our guide and our example? The complete righteousness that marked the life of our savior was due to the unity of His Divine and Human will. Also, the crucifixion was the choice of both the Divine and Human will. Had it not been one will, it would not have been said that He died by His own will for us. And since the will is one, the act is also one.

+ This Lecture is adapted from ‘The Nature of Christ’ by H.H. Pope Shenouda III.

+ The human nature actually consists of three elements: The body, the spirit and the soul. As St. Paul said, “May your whole spirit, soul, and body be preserved blameless” (1Thess 5:23). Only two are mentioned above for simplicity. But we need to understand that our Lord had a FULL human nature.

“Wisdom [our Lord Jesus Christ] has built her house [the Church], She has hewn out her seven pillars [the seven Sacraments]” (Prov 9:1)

+ Lecture 1: What is a Sacrament? +

+ Introduction: To materialists, this world is opaque like a curtain; nothing can be seen through it. A mountain is just a mountain, a sunset just a sunset; but to poets, artists and saints, the world is transparent like a windowpane it tells of something beyond. For example, a mountain tells of the power of God, the sunset of His beauty, and the snow white of His purity. A Sacrament, in a very broad sense of the term, combines two elements: one visible, the other invisible ~ one can be seen, or tasted, or touched, or heard while the other remains unseen to the eyes of the flesh. There is, however, some kind of relation or significance between the two. A spoken word is a kind of sacrament because there is something material or audible about it; there is also something spiritual about it, namely, its meaning. A horse can hear a funny story just as well as a man. It is conceivable that the horse may even hear the words better than the man and at the end of the story the man may laugh, but the horse will never give a horselaugh. The reason is that the horse gets the material side of the ‘sacrament’ namely the sound, but man gets the invisible or the spiritual side, namely, the meaning. A handshake is a kind of sacrament, because there is something seen and felt, namely the clasping of the hands, but there is something mysterious and unseen, namely, the communication of friendship. A kiss is a kind of sacrament, the physical side of it is present if one kisses one’s own hand, but the spiritual side of it is missing because there is no sign of affection for another. No wonder our Lord said to Judas, “are you betraying the son of Man with a kiss?” (Jn 22:48)

Take the brazen serpent in the desert. When the Jewish people were bitten by poisonous serpents, God commanded Moses to make a brazen serpent, and to hang it over the crotch of a tree (Num 21:8-9); all who would look upon that serpent of brass would be healed of the serpent’s sting. This apparently was a rather ridiculous remedy for poison and not everyone looked at it. If one could discern or guess their reason, it would probably be because they concentrated on only one side of the symbol, namely, the shiny, lifeless brass thing hanging on a pole. But it proved to be a symbol of faith; God used that material thing as a symbol of trust or faith in Him. The symbolism goes still further, the Old Testament is fulfilled in our Lord Jesus Christ who revealed the full mystery of the brazen serpent. Our Lord told Nicodemus that the brass serpent was lifted up in the desert so that He would have to be lifted up on the cross (Jn 3:14). The meaning now becomes clear; the brass serpent in the desert looked like the serpent that bit the people, but though it seemed to be the same, it was actually without any poison. Our Blessed Lord now says that He is like that brazen serpent.

He, too, would be lifted up on the crotch of a tree, a cross. He would look as if He Himself was filled with the poison of sin, for His body would bear the marks, and the stings, and the piercing of sin; and yet as the brass serpent was without poison so He would be without sin. As those who looked upon that brass serpent in the desert in faith were healed of the bite of the serpent, so all who would look upon Him on His cross bearing the sins and poisons of the world would also be healed of the poison of the serpent, Satan.

The word “sacrament” in Greek means “mystery”, and our Lord Jesus Christ has been called by St. Paul “a great mystery” (1 Tim 3:16). In Him is something divine, something human, something eternal, something temporal, something invisible, something visible. The Human Nature of our Blessed Lord had no power to sanctify of and by itself; that is to say, apart from its union with the Divinity, but because of that union, the Humanity of the Lord became the efficient cause of our justification and sanctification and will be until the end of the world. Herein is hidden a hint of the Sacraments. The Humanity of the Lord was the bearer of Divine life and the means of making men holy, the Sacraments were also to become the effective means of the sanctification purchased by his death. As our Blessed Lord was the sensible sign of God (He is truly God), so the Sacraments were to become the sensible signs of the grace (they are truly grace), which our Lord had won for us.

If men were angels or pure spirits, there would have been no need of our Lord Jesus Christ using human nature or material things for the communication of the divine, but because man is composed of matter and spirit, body and soul, man functions best when he sees the material as the revealer of the spiritual. From the very beginning of man's life, his mother's fondling is not merely to leave an impress upon his infant body, but rather to communicate the sublimely beautiful and invisible love of the mother. It is not the material thing that man values, but rather what is signified by it.

+ **Sacraments and Salvation:**

One often sees signs painted on roadways, "Jesus saves". Now this indeed is true, but the important question is how does He save? What relation do we have in the twenty-first century to our Lord Jesus Christ in the first? Do we establish contact with Him only by reading about Him? If that were all, our relationship is not much closer than that which we can have with Plato. If the Lord Jesus Christ is only a memory of someone who lived centuries ago, then it is rather difficult to see that His influence will be any different than that of Socrates or Buddha. The answer to the question of how our Lord Jesus Christ saves is to be found in the Sacraments. The Divine life of the Lord is communicated through His Church or His mystical body in exactly the same way that His divine life was communicated when He walked on earth. As He then used His human nature as the instrument of divinity and used material things as means to confer His grace; clay and water in the case of the born blind (Jn 9:11). He now uses other human natures (priests) and material things (water, bread and wine, oil) as instruments for the communication of the same divine life (grace).

Every Sacrament has an outward or visible sign. For example, in Baptism it is water, in the Eucharist it is bread and wine, but the Sacrament also has a form or formula, words of spiritual significance given to the matter when it is conferred. Three things then are absolutely required for a Sacrament: (1) Its institution by the Lord Jesus Christ, (2) an outward sign, (3) the power of conferring the grace purchased for us by the Passion, Death, and Resurrection of the Lord.

Calvary is like a reservoir of divine life or grace. From it, there flows seven different kinds of sanctification for man in different stages in his spiritual existence. Each of these seven channels is a Sacrament by which the power of the Risen Christ is bestowed on souls by a spiritual and effective contact. This divine grace pours into the soul when we receive the Sacraments, unless we put an obstacle in the way, just as water will not flow out of a faucet if we put our hand in front of the faucet. But the faucet in a house has no power to quench thirst unless there is a reservoir and a pipeline. So the Sacraments do not confer grace as magical signs, they communicate it only because they are in contact with the Risen Christ through the work of the Holy Spirit about Whom the Lord said, "He will take of what is Mine and declare it to you." (Jn 17:14)



+ **The Seven Holy Sacraments:**

1. The Sacrament of Holy Orders (Priesthood)
2. The Sacrament of Baptism
3. The Sacrament of Confirmation
4. The Sacrament of The Eucharist
5. The Sacrament of Repentance & Confession
6. The Sacrament of The Anointing of The Sick
7. The Sacrament of Matrimony

(Adapted from 'These are the Sacraments' by Fulton J. Sheen & Yousuf Karsh.)

Q: The word “mystery” occurred in Holy Scripture with many meanings, how are these meanings different from the “Sacraments” of the Church?

A: The word “mystery” in Holy Scripture has two meanings:

1. Mysteries of knowledge that God reveals (Secrets or Hidden Truths).
2. Mysteries of grace where the Holy Spirits grants invisible gifts (Sacraments).

1. Mysteries of Knowledge:

- “The secret of the Lord is with those who fear Him” (**Ps 25:14**)
- “Surely the Lord God does nothing unless He reveals His secret to His servants the prophets” (**Amos 3:7**)
- “Then the secret was revealed to Daniel” (**An 2:19**)
- “To you it has been given to know the mysteries [hidden truths] of the Kingdom of God” (**Lk 8:10**)
- “We speak the wisdom of God in a mystery, the hidden wisdom which God ordained before the ages for our glory” (**1 Cor 2:7**)
- “Though I have the gift of prophecy, and understand all mysteries and all knowledge but have not love, I am nothing” (**1 Cor 13:2**)
- “Having made known to us the mystery of His will” (**Eph 1:9**)
- “That I may open my mouth boldly to make known the mystery of the gospel” (**Eph 6:19**)
- “The mystery [secret or hidden truth] which has been hidden from ages and from generations, but now has been revealed to His saints” (**Col 1:26**)
- “Meanwhile praying also for us, that God would open to us a door for the word, to speak the mystery [hidden truth] of Christ” (**Col 4:3**)
- “The knowledge of the mystery of God, both of the Father and of Christ” (**Col 2:2**)
- “Great is the mystery [hidden truth] of godliness: God was manifested in the flesh” (**1 Tim 3:16**)

2. Mysteries of Grace:

The word Sacrament is the conjunction of the Latin word *sacer* (holy) with the Greek word *mysterion* (secret rite). Sacrament was thus given a sacred mysterious significance that indicated a spiritual potency. The power was transmitted through material instruments and vehicles viewed as channels of divine grace and as *benefis* in ritual observance instituted by Christ. St. Augustine defines Sacraments as *The visible form of an invisible grace*’ (Encyclopedia Britannica; Volume 26, Page 834)

- “A man shall leave his father and mother and be joined to his wife, and the two shall become one flesh. This is a great mystery [Sacrament] but I speak concerning Christ and the Church” (**Eph 5:31-32**)



“Purge me with hyssop, and I shall be clean; wash me and I shall be whiter than snow.” (Ps 51:7)

+ **Lecture V: The Sacrament of Baptism**

Baptism is the Holy Sacrament through which we are born again by being immersed in water three times in the name of the Holy Trinity: the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit. The Sacrament of Baptism has the primacy among the Seven Holy Sacraments for it is the door through which the individual enters the Church (as a congregation) and is given the right to partake of the rest of the Sacraments.

+ **Institution of The Sacrament:**

Lord Jesus Christ instituted this Sacrament after His blessed resurrection, having completed our redemption and having made salvation available, He said to His disciples, “All authority has been given to Me in heaven and on earth. Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit” (**Mt 28:18-19**), and “He who believes and is baptized will be saved; but he who does not believe will be condemned” (Mk 16:16). Thus baptism is necessary for salvation as the Lord indicated, “Most assuredly, I say to you, unless one is born of water and the Spirit, he cannot enter the Kingdom of God” (**Jn 3:5**)

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+ **How Exactly Does Baptism Save Us?**

Salvation simply means remission of sins and it is written, “Without shedding of blood [death] there is no remission” (**Heb 9:22**). Salvation is made available through the redemptive death of Lord Jesus Christ on the cross. In order to have a share in this salvation, we must share the death and resurrection of the Lord. Therefore, St. Paul said, “That I may know Him and the power of His resurrection and the fellowship of His suffering being conformed to His death” (**Phil 3:10**). Unless a person undergoes such death, he/she will not be saved! Now how can we undergo such death? How can we share the death of the Lord? The answer is “Through Baptism”. St. Paul said, “Or do you not know that as many of you were baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into His death? Therefore we were buried with Him through baptism into death” (**Rom 6:3-4**). It is our death and burial with the Lord through baptism that saves us and makes us share the glories of His Resurrection. St. Paul affirms, “For if we have been united together in the likeness of His death [baptism], certainly we shall be in the likeness of His resurrection... now if we died with Christ, we believe that we shall also live with Him” (Rom 6:25-8). The salvation that began with our death and burial with Lord Jesus through baptism continues to be effective in us also through death. We obtain salvation through death and our bodies must always remain dead in relation to worldly lusts. For as long as the body is dead to sin, salvation lives in it, but when carnal lusts rise from this death, we become liable to lose our salvation since salvation is only attained through death.

Hence St. Paul exhorts us saying:

- “Reckon yourselves to be dead indeed to sin, but alive to God in Christ our Lord. Therefore do not let sin reign in your mortal body that you should obey it in its lusts.” (**Rom 6:11-12**).
- “If by the Spirit you put to death the deeds of the body, you will live.” (**Rom 8:13**)
- “Those who are Christ’s have crucified the flesh and its passions and desires.” (**Gal 5:24**)
- “I have been crucified with Christ; it is no longer I who live, but Christ lives in me.” (**Gal 2:20**)
- “For you died, and your life is hidden with Christ in God.” (**Col 3:3**)
- “Always carrying about in the body the dying of the Lord Jesus.” (**2Cor 4:10**)
- “Therefore put to death your members which are on earth: fornication, uncleanness, passion, evil desire, and covetousness, which is idolatry.” (**Col 3:5**) “He who has died has been freed from sin.” (**Rom 6:7**)

The salvation that we obtained through baptism continues with us through death. Thus we pray saying, “O, who tasted death in the flesh in the ninth hour for our sake, we sinners, put to death our carnal lusts, O, Christ, our God, and deliver us” (From the prayer of the 9th hour — Coptic Book of Hours).

+ **Symbols of Baptism in The Old Testament:**

1. It is written in the Holy Book of Genesis, “The Spirit of God was hovering over the face of the waters” (**Gen 1:2**). This is both a symbol and a prophecy about the work of the Holy Spirit in baptismal water to give it its saving efficacy.
2. St. Peter interpreted the story of Noah’s ark and the flood (Gen 7) as a symbol of baptism, he said, “The divine longsuffering waited in the days of Noah, while the ark was being prepared, in which a few, that is, eight souls, were saved through water. There is also an antitype which now saves us — baptism (not the removal of the filth of the flesh, but the answer of a good conscience toward God), through the resurrection of Jesus Christ” (**1 Pet 3:20-21**) Notice the link between baptism and salvation through the resurrection of the Lord.
3. St. Paul interprets the commandment of circumcision (Gen 17) as a symbol of baptism, he said, “You were also circumcised with the circumcision made without hands, by putting off the body of the sins of the flesh, by the circumcision of Christ, buried with Him in baptism, in which you also were raised with Him through faith in the working of God who raised Him from the dead” (**Col 2:11-12**) Notice the link between baptism and salvation (through the resurrection of the Lord) for God said about the child who is not circumcised that he will be “cut off from his people, he has broken My covenant” (**Gen 17:14**). Likewise, a child who is not baptized cannot enter the Kingdom of God (**Jn 3:5**)
4. The relation between the ark, the circumcision, the saving resurrection of the Lord, and baptism goes even further. Notice that St. Peter emphasizes that only eight souls were saved from the evil world through the water of the flood. Also notice that God ordered that children must be circumcised on the eighth day. Now the Lord’s resurrection took place on the first day of the week (**J11 20:1**) that is the eighth day from the previous week. The number eight represents the new life and eternity. In fact number eight is the only number (**from 1-10**) that does not have a beginning and end (8), which is basically the definition of eternity.
5. St. Paul interpreted the story of crossing the sea (Ex 14) as a symbol of baptism, he said, “All our fathers were under the cloud, all passed through the sea, all were baptized into Moses in the cloud and in the sea” (**1 Cor 10:1-2**). The sea was a symbol of the baptismal water that draws its saving efficacy from the precious blood of our Lord (no wonder its called the Red Sea), the cloud was a symbol of the Holy Spirit who works through the baptismal water, and Pharaoh was a symbol of the devil who is destroyed by the cross of Lord Jesus through the water of baptism.
6. The Priesthood was not given to Aaron and his sons except after being washed with water (**Ex 29:4**), also the laver of bronze and it’s water set between the tabernacle of meeting and the alter (**Ex 30: 18**) was a symbol of the spiritual cleansing effect of baptismal water.
7. The sacrifice of Elijah the Prophet was accepted after pouring water on it three times (**1 Kgs 18:34**). Moreover, Elijah himself was not taken up to heaven until he crossed the waters of the Jordan river (**2 Kgs 2:8**). The same happened with the Israelites who went into the Promised Land after going through the waters of the Jordan (Joshua 3). In the Holy Book of Revelation we read about “a sea of glass” (**Rev 4:6**) before the throne of God. The point is that we must go through the waters of baptism to reach heavenly Promised Land and enjoy the company of God.

+ **The Baptism of St. John The Baptist:**



No pre—Pentecostal baptism can be equated with Christian baptism. This not only includes St. John the Baptist's but also the disciples' baptisms during the life of the Lord on earth (**Jn 4:2**). These baptisms were preparatory ones, just for repentance, as St. John said, "I indeed baptize you with water unto repentance, but He who is coming after me is mightier than I. He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit and fire" (**Mt 3:11**). The redemption had not yet been accomplished; the specific relationship of baptism with the cross and the blood of the Lord had not yet been established. Moreover, the gift of the Holy Spirit was not yet available (**Jn 7:37-39**). On the day of Pentecost no exceptions were allowed for those who may have received St. John's baptism, St. Peter said, "Let every one of you be baptized" (**Acts 2:38**)

The Holy Book of Acts tells us of a specific incidence where some believers at Ephesus were only baptized with St. John's baptism so St. Paul asked, "Did you receive the Holy Spirit when you believed?" They replied, "We have not so much as heard whether there is a Holy Spirit." He wondered, "Into what then were you baptized?" So they said, "Into John's baptism" Then St. Paul explained, "John indeed baptized with a baptism of repentance, saying to the people that they should believe on Him who would come after him, that is on Christ Jesus." So when they heard this, they were baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus. (**Acts 19:1-5**)

+ **The Effectiveness of Baptismal Water:**

It may be objected, "What does mere water do when a person is immersed in it?" One might just as well ask, what does water do when poured into the boiler? The water in the boiler can do nothing of and by itself, nor can the water in the baptistery, but when the water in the boiler is united with the mind of an engineer, it can drive an engine across a continent or a ship across the sea. So too, when water is united with the power of the Holy Spirit, it can give regeneration and spiritual cleansing. Those who think that the effectiveness of baptism depends on the water alone bring to mind the story of Naaman (**2 Kgs 5**), the commander of the Syrian army, who was a leper. This man came to Elisha the Prophet to be healed from leprosy so he told him, "Go and wash in the Jordan seven times, and your flesh shall be restored to you, and you shall be clean" (**2 Kgs 5:10**). Naaman was insulted and became furious; he said angrily, "Are not the Abanah and the Pharpar, the rivers of Damascus, better than all the waters of Israel? Could I not wash in them and be clean?" (**2 Kgs 5:12**). His servants, however, said to him, "My father, if the prophet had told you to do something great, would you not have done it? How much more then, when he says to you, 'Wash and be clean'?" (**2 Kgs 5:13**). So Naaman went down and dipped in the Jordan and he was healed! Likewise, if the blind man from birth had questioned the words of Lord Jesus about washing in the pool of Siloam (**Jn 9:11**), he would have remained blind. Our Lord emphasized the relation between the water and the Spirit (**Jn 3:5—6**) thus baptismal water is not to be considered mere water for "There are three that bear witness on earth: The Spirit, the water, and the blood; and these three agree as one. (**1 Jn 5:7**)

+ **Immersion Vs Sprinkling:**

To baptize (Gr. *Baptizo*) literally means to immerse or to put into. Therefore, the Orthodox Church baptizes by triple immersion, “in the name of the Father, and the Son, and the Holy Spirit” (**Mt 28:19**). Baptism by immersion is supported also by the following biblical examples:

- “Both Philip and the eunuch went down into the water, and he baptized him. Now when they came out of the water, the Spirit of the Lord caught Philip away” (**Acts 8:38-39**). If baptism were by sprinkling, St. Philip could have just brought water to the chariot and sprinkled it on the eunuch.
- St. Paul said, “We were buried with Him through baptism” (**Rom 6:4**), and “Buried with Him in baptism” (**Col 2:12**). The only way a person is buried in baptism is through complete immersion.
- St. Paul said, “According to His mercy He saved us, through the washing of regeneration and renewing of the Holy Spirit” (**Titus 3:5**), St. Ananias said to St. Paul (Saul), “Be baptized, and wash away your sins” (**Acts 22:16**). Baptism is also called “washing” in (**1 Pet 3:18-21; Eph 5:26**). To wash a piece of cloth you need to completely immerse it in water.

Because baptism is a very important condition for salvation (**Mk 16:16; Jn 3:5**) the Church allows baptism by sprinkling only in the case where immersion is prevented by a medical condition and there is a risk that the person would die without being baptized. For example, a newborn with a fatal health condition that is kept in an incubator cannot be immersed three times in water, so the Church allows sprinkling in this instance. Moreover, if there was no priest available, any Orthodox Christian (male or female) can perform the baptism by anointing the baby with water three times saying, “I baptize you in the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit”. If the baby lives, baptism is not repeated and the child just needs to be anointed with the Holy oil.

+ **Why Do We Baptize Infants?**

1. Baptism is essential for salvation and without it a person cannot enter the Kingdom of God, “Most assuredly I say to you, unless a person is born of water and the Spirit, he cannot enter the Kingdom of God” (**Jn 3:5**). Infants are no exception since they are born with the corrupt nature due to the original sin. Therefore, infants are baptized to insure their salvation.
2. Circumcision was a symbol of baptism (**Col 2:11-13**). Now if God commanded that infants enter in the Old Covenant with Him, should we prevent them from entering in the New Covenant?
3. Crossing the Red Sea was also a symbol of baptism (**1 Cor 10:1-2**). Undoubtedly, infants crossed the sea with their parents so why should today’s infants be prevented from being baptized?
4. St. Peter said to the people on Pentecost, “Be baptized... and you shall receive the gift of the Holy Spirit. For the promise is to you and to your children” (**Acts 2:38-39**). This is a clear implication that children are accepted in baptism.
5. Holy Scripture records several occasions where families and entire households were baptized together (**Acts 16:14-15, 33; 1 Cor 1:16**). This is another implication that children were baptized.
6. There is not a single biblical verse that supports the prevention of infants’ baptism. On the contrary, our Lord said, “Let the little children come to Me, and do not forbid them; for of such is the kingdom of heaven” (**Mt 19:14**), and “Take heed that you do not despise one of these little ones, for I say to you that in heaven their angels always see the face of My Father who is in heaven” (**Mt 18:10**)

+ **One Baptism:**

The Sacrament of Baptism is performed once and is not repeated as we say in the creed, “we confess one baptism for the remission of sins”. Since baptism is a spiritual birth so a person is born (baptized) once and since baptism is death with the Lord and the Lord died once so a person dies with the Lord (baptized) once. Thus St. Paul said, “one Lord, one faith, one baptism” (**Eph 4:5**)

+ **FAQ:**

Q1: If baptism is necessary for salvation, were the people of the Old Testament baptized?

A1: Baptism was not a condition for salvation in the Old Testament, but it was only instituted as a condition in the New Testament, “He who believes and is baptized will be saved” (**Mk 16:16**). The reason is that baptism’s saving efficacy is linked to the death of Lord Jesus Christ and the Lord had not yet died in the Old Testament. Had baptism existed in the Old Testament, people would have had to be baptized in order to be saved. Nevertheless, the people of the Old Testament practiced the symbol of baptism available to them at such time, namely circumcision (**Col 2:11-13**). They also kept the Passover, which was a symbol of our Lord (**1 Cor 5:7**)

Q2: What is the fate of infants who die without being baptized?

A2: Lord Jesus Christ said, “Most assuredly, I say to you, unless one is born again, he cannot see the Kingdom of God” (**Jn 3:3**), and “Most assuredly, I say to you, unless one is born of water and the Spirit, he cannot enter the kingdom of God” (**Jn 3:5**). These infants inherited the corrupt nature due to the original sin, “we were by nature children of wrath” (**Eph 2:3**) and St. Paul affirms that corruption does not inherit incorruption (**1 Cor 15:50**). Therefore, these infants cannot enter nor see the Kingdom of God. One may object, “They didn’t do anything wrong!” Well, they didn’t do anything right either. The early Church fathers agree that these infants will not enter the Kingdom of God (based on the words of the Lord) but concerning suffering and punishment the most probable and most acceptable opinion is that they will not suffer since they did not commit any personal sin (St. Gregory the Theologian).

God said, “the uncircumcised male child, who is not circumcised in the flesh of his foreskin, that person (that child) shall be cut off from his people; he has broken My covenant” (**Gen 17:14**). Someone may ask, “What about God’s mercy?” God’s mercy is full of justice and His Justice is full of mercy. So trust in the merciful justice of our God and don’t worry about this subject.

* This lecture is adapted from ‘The Church Sacraments’ by Archdeacon Habib Guirgess.



“I will give you a new heart and put a new spirit within you; I will take the heart of stone out of your flesh and give you a heart of flesh. I will put My Spirit within you and cause you to walk in My statutes.” (Ezek 36:26-27)

+ **Lecture X: The Sacrament of Confirmation** +

In the biological order, a creature must first be born, and then it must grow. Likewise, in the spiritual order of grace, we are born again in Baptism and then we must grow in the spiritual life and bear the fruits of the Spirit (Gal 5:22-23). We also need to acquire the spiritual power that will enable us to overcome Satan and his army “for we do not wrestle against flesh and blood, but against principalities, against powers, against the rulers of the darkness of this age, against spiritual hosts of wickedness in the heavenly places” (Eph 6:12). The Holy Sacrament of Confirmation induces us into God’s spiritual army and the lay priesthood of believers. Our body becomes a temple of the Holy Spirit (1 Cor 6:19) who helps us grow in the spiritual life. Confirmation is a kind of Pentecost to the baptized person.

+ **Institution of the Sacrament:**

The roots of this Sacrament are clear in both the Old and New Testaments. In his sermon on Pentecost, St. Peter quotes the famous words of Joel the Prophet; “I will pour out My Spirit on all flesh” (Acts 2:17; Joel 2:28). Other Old Testament prophets who speak of this same promise of the Spirit include Ezekiel (Ezek 16:9; 36:26-27). Moreover, our Lord Jesus Christ instituted this Holy Sacrament through His various promises for granting the Holy Spirit:

- *“If anyone thirsts, let him come to Me and drink. He who believes in Me, as the Scripture has said, out of his heart will flow rivers of living water. But this He spoke concerning the Spirit, whom those believing in Him would receive; for the Holy Spirit was not yet given, because Jesus was not yet glorified.” (Jn 7:37-38)*
- *“And I will pray to the Father, and He will give you another Helper, that He may abide with you forever — the Spirit of truth, whom the world cannot receive, because it neither sees Him nor knows Him; but you know Him, for He dwells with you and will be in you.” (Jn 14:16-17)*
- *“But the Helper, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in My name, He will teach you all things, and bring to your remembrance all things that I said to you.” (Jn 14:26)*
- *“But when the Helper comes, whom I shall send to you from the Father, the Spirit of truth who proceeds from the Father, He will testify of Me.” (Jn 15:26)*
- *“Nevertheless I tell you the truth. It is to your advantage that I go away; for if I do not go away, the Helper will not come to you; but if I depart I will send Him to you.” (Jn 16:7)*
- *“And being assembled together with them, He commanded them not to depart from Jerusalem, but to wait for the promise of the Father, ‘which,’ He said, ‘you have heard from Me; for John truly baptized with water, but you shall be baptized with the Holy Spirit not many days from now.’” (Acts 1:4—5)*

+ **Independence From Baptism:**

- *“Now when the apostles who were at Jerusalem heard that Samaria had received the word of God, they sent Peter and John to them, who, when they had come down, prayed for them that they might receive the Holy Spirit. For as yet He had fallen upon none of them. They had only been baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus. Then they laid hands on them, and they received the Holy Spirit.” (Acts 8:14-17)*
- *“When they heard this, they were baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus. And when Paul had laid hands on them, the Holy Spirit came upon them.” (Acts 19:25-6)*
- *The independence of Confirmation (laying of hands) from Baptism is explicit in Heb 6:2 where the apostle distinguishes “the doctrine of baptisms” from the doctrine “of laying on of hands.”*

+ **Administration of the Sacrament:**

Our fathers the Apostles administered this Sacrament by laying on of hands directly after Baptism as mentioned in the Holy Book of Acts (**Acts 8:14-17; 19:5-6**). Laying on of hands for the dwelling of the Holy Spirit is a specific rite of the Apostles (and their successors the Bishops). In Acts 8, Philip, the deacon and evangelist, preached and baptized the people of Samaria but did not grant them the gift of the Holy Spirit. The Apostles came and later confirmed these new believers with the gift of the Holy Spirit through the laying on of hands (Acts 8:14-17). As the number of believers increased, it was not possible for the Apostles to wander all countries and cities to lay hands on the baptized. So they established Chrismation (Gr. *chrismatis*, “*anointing*”) in addition to the laying on of hands:

- “You have an anointing from the Holy One.” (**1 Jn 2:20**)
- “The anointing which you have received from Him abides in you the same anointing teaches you concerning all things.” (**1 Jn 2:27**)
- “He who establishes us with you in Christ and has anointed us is God, who also sealed us and given us the Spirit in our hearts as a guarantee.” (**2 Cor 1:21-22**)
- “And do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God, by whom you were sealed for the day of redemption. (**Eph 4:30**)

+ **History of The Holy Oil (Myron -) Greek word that means perfume:**

Our fathers the Apostles took the spices that were on our Lord’s body in the tomb and the spices that the women had prepared (**Lk 24:1**), melted all in pure olive oil, and prayed on it. They decreed that this holy oil be used as means of anointing the baptized in order to confirm and give them the gift of the Holy Spirit. They also decided that their successors, the Bishops, renew the holy oil by adding to the original so that the Churches never run out. When St. Mark came to Alexandria, he brought with him some of that holy oil. In the beginning of the fourth century, H.H. Pope Athanasius the Apostolic, the 20th Pope of Alexandria, decided to renew the holy oil. So he gathered all the spices and perfumes that God had ordered Moses the Prophet to use in making the holy ointment (**Ex 30**) and added them to the remainder of the holy oil that St. Mark had brought with him to Egypt. St. Athanasius sent some of the holy oil to the Bishops of Rome, Antioch, and Constantinople with the recipe that he used in manufacturing it and they all received it with rejoicing. The holy oil was manufactured 29 times in the Coptic Orthodox Church (thus far).

+ **Chrismation of Infants:**

The Orthodox Churches administer Chrismation immediately following baptism in accordance with the teachings of the Holy Bible and the Apostolic Tradition, but the Roman Catholic Church has started since the 13th century to delay the confirmation of infants until they are 7 or 12 years old and consequently delays their participation in the Holy Eucharist. This delay is totally unjustified, wasn’t St. John the Baptist filled with the Holy Spirit while still in his mother’s womb (**Lk 1:15**)?

+ **Chrismation & Our Salvation:**

H.H. Pope Shenouda III said, “We can never be saved without this gift of the Holy Spirit because our whole spiritual life is the response of our will to the work of the Holy Spirit within us. Unless we receive the gift of the Holy Spirit, all our life will be futile and subject to perdition. It is a gift that we receive through the Sacrament of the Holy Unction and for which we pray continually saying ‘Do not take Your Holy Spirit from me’ (**Ps 51:11**) otherwise we shall perish.”

* This lecture is adapted from “The Sacraments of the Church ” by Archdeacon Habib Guirgess.

“I acknowledged my sin to You, and my iniquity I have not hidden. I said, ‘I will confess my transgression to the Lord,’ and You forgave the iniquity of my sin.” (Ps 32:5)

+ **Lecture XV: The Sacrament of Repentance & Confession** +

In the biological order, when a baby is born, it is generally healthy, but as time goes on, it becomes subject to diseases that oppress and torment life. In the spiritual order, too, though the soul is made clean and free from all sin by baptism, it nevertheless contracts stains and spiritual diseases during life. The Sacrament of Repentance and Confession is for spiritual wounds received after baptism. Original Sin was washed from the infant in baptism and from the adult, personal sins as well. Fortunately, the Lord is Practical, *“For He knows our frame; He remembers that we are dust” (Ps 103:14)*. He also knows that the white robe given to us in baptism is not always kept immaculate. Therefore, in His mercy, He instituted this Sacrament for spiritual guidance, healing, and reconciliation with Him.

+ **Institution of the Sacrament:**

Lord Jesus Christ instituted this Sacrament when He said to His disciples:

- *“Assuredly, I say to you, whatever you bind on earth will be bound in heaven, and whatever you loose on earth will be loosed in heaven.” (Mt 18:18)*
- *“Receive the Holy Spirit. If you forgive the sins of any, they are forgiven them; if you retain the sins of any, they are retained.” (Jn 20:22-23)*

The above words imply *“hearing confessions”* because how would the disciples know which sins to forgive and which sins not to forgive if they did not hear them? Therefore it was written:

- *“Many who had believed came confessing and telling their deeds.” (Acts 19:18)*

+ **Roots of the Sacrament in the Old Testament:**

All through the Old Testament, there was a preparation for this Sacrament, in as much as God strove to induce men to acknowledge their sins before Him:

- To elicit a confession, God asked Adam, *“Have you eaten from the tree of which I commanded you that you should not eat?” (Gen 3:11)* Likewise, He asked Cain after killing his brother Abel, *“Where is Abel your brother?” (Gen 4:9)*
- God ordered the children of Israel to confess their sins:
 - a) *“And it shall be, when he is guilty in any of these matters, that he shall confess that he has sinned in that thing So the priest shall make atonement for him concerning his sin.” (Lev 5:5-6)*
 - b) *“When a man or woman commits any sin that person is guilty, then he shall confess the sin that he has done. He shall make restitution for his trespass in full value.” (Num 5:6-7)*
 - c) *“If they confess their iniquity then I will remember My covenant...” (Lev 26:40,42)*
- King Solomon said, *“He who covers his sins will not prosper, but whoever confesses and forsakes them will have mercy” (Prov 28:13)*
- Joshua said to Achan, *“Give glory to the Lord God of Israel, and make confession to Him, and tell me now what you have done; do not hide it from me” (Josh 7:19)*
- King David confessed to Nathan the Prophet saying, *“I have sinned against the Lord.” (2 Sam 12:13)*

It is no surprise then to read that Jerusalem, all Judea, and the entire region around the Jordan went out to St. John the Baptist and *“were baptized by him in the Jordan, confessing their sins” (Mt 3:6)*. All these were only types and figures of the Sacrament that was to come because forgiveness became possible only through the merits of our Lord’s passion.



+ **Stages (Types) of Confession:**

1. Confession to one's self: This is the first thing one needs to do as Lord Jesus Christ mentioned in His parable of the Prodigal Son that "he came to himself" (**Lk 15:17**)
2. Confession to God: Once a person acknowledges the sin, he/she should lift up his/her heart and confess this sin to God as King David said, "Against You, You only, have I sinned, and done this evil in Your sight" (**Psa 51:4**)
3. Confession to the priest: This is the practice of the Sacrament of Repentance & Confession where the confessor receives spiritual guidance and forgiveness as St. James said, "Is anyone among you sick? Let him call for the elders (priests) of the Church, and let them pray over him, anointing him with oil in the name of the Lord Confess your trespasses to one another, and pray for one another, that you may be healed" (**Jam 5:14,16**). When St. James says "pray for one another," he is referring to the priests praying for the sick and when he says, "confess to one another," he means the sick confessing to the priests.
4. Confession to the person against whom the trespass was committed: With the guidance and advice of the father of confession, the confessor may be required to confess to the person against whom he/she sinned with the willingness to restore genuine Christian fellowship with that person.

+ **The Unacceptable Confession:**

Confession without repentance and without hope is not acceptable to God and will not benefit the person anything. For example, Pharaoh confessed his sin to Moses the Prophet several times and Judas confessed saying, "I have sinned by betraying innocent blood" (**Mt 27:4**), but both of them perished.

+ **The Acceptable Confession:**

1. The acceptable Confession must be accompanied by Repentance which is characterized by:
 - a) Contrite heart and regret, "Now, therefore, says the Lord, turn to Me with all your heart, with fasting, with weeping, and with mourning" (**Joel 2:12**). — "For godly sorrow produces repentance to salvation, not to be regretted; but the sorrow of the world produces death" (**2 Cor 7:10**)
 - b) Steadfast intention to never go back to sin, "See, you have been made well. Sin no more, lest a worse thing come upon you" (**Jn 5:14**) — "We are not of those who draw back to perdition" (**Heb 10:39**) — "It would have been better for them not to have known the way of righteousness, than having known it, to turn from the holy commandment delivered to them. But it has happened to them according to the true proverb: A dog returns to his own vomit, and, a sow, having washed, to her wallowing in the mire" (**2 Pet 2:21-22**)
 - c) Steadfast faith in Lord Jesus Christ and His grace, "Do not rejoice over me, my enemy; when I fall, I will arise; when I sit in darkness, the Lord will be a light to me." (**Mic 7:8**)

The acceptable Confession must be preceded by self—examination.

The confessor must:

- a) Not excuse his/her self, "Do not let your mouth cause your flesh to sin, nor say before the messenger of God that it was an error. Why should God be angry at your excuse and destroy the work of your hands?" (**Ecc 5:6**)
- b) Not hide anything from the father of confession, "Pour out your heart like water before the face of the Lord" (**Lament 2:19**)
- c) Be truthful in his/her confession, remember Sapphira who lied to St. Peter in her confession (**Acts 5**)
- d) Not have any bias toward his/her self, "He who loves his life will lose it" (**Jn 12:25**)

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"You prepare a table before me in the presence of my enemies."
(Ps 23:5)

+ Lecture XI: The Sacrament of The Eucharist +

In the Sacrament of the Eucharist, believers eat Lord Jesus Christ's Holy Body and drink His precious Blood under the physical appearance of bread and wine. This Sacrament is called the Sacrament of all Sacraments and/or the crown of the Sacraments. In the Coptic Orthodox Church, no Sacrament is to be administered (on the same day) after the person has partaken from Holy Communion.

+ Institution of the Sacrament:

Our Lord instituted this Sacrament on Covenant Thursday, just a few hours before His arrest and trial. After He had washed the feet of the disciples as a sign of their repentance and preparation, "He took bread, blessed it and broke it, and gave it to the disciples and said, Take, eat; this is My body." Then He took the cup, and gave thanks, and gave it to them, saying Drink from it all of you. For this is My blood of the new covenant, which is shed for many for the remission of sins'" (Mt 26:26-28)
St. Paul said, "The Lord Jesus on the same night in which He was betrayed took bread; and when He had given thanks, He broke it and said, 'Take, eat; this is My body which is broken for you; do this in remembrance of Me.' In the same manner He also took the cup after supper, saying, 'This cup is the new covenant in My blood. This do, as often as you drink it, in remembrance of Me.' For as often as you eat this bread and drink this cup, you proclaim the Lord's death till He comes"
(1 Cor 11:23-26)

+ Symbols of the Eucharist in the Old Testament:

The offering of Melchizedek (bread & wine) was a symbol of this Holy Sacrament, "Melchizedek king of Salem brought out bread and wine; he was the priest of God Most High" (Gen 14:18). This is the first verse in Holy Scripture where the word "priest" was used and it is interesting to notice the connection between the priesthood of Melchizedek and the offering of bread and wine. Therefore, it was said about our Lord, "You are a priest forever according to the order of Melchizedek" (Ps 110:4; Heb 5:6)
The Passover lamb that the children of Israel offered on the night of their exodus from Egypt, and which they used to offer every year thereafter was a symbol of this Sacrament "For indeed Christ, our Passover, was sacrificed for us" (1 Cor 5:7)
The manna that the children of Israel ate in the wilderness of Sinai for forty years was a symbol of the Sacrament of Eucharist. Our Lord said, "This is the bread which came down from heaven not as your fathers ate the manna, and are dead. He who eats this bread will live forever" (Jn 6:58)
"I am the living bread which came down from heaven. If anyone eats of this bread, he will live forever and the bread that I shall give is My flesh" (Jn 6:51)

+ **The Question of the Real Presence:**

Our Lord spoke about this Sacrament openly to the Jews but they “quarreled among themselves saying, ‘How can this Man give us His flesh to eat?’” (Jn 6:52). Moreover, many of the disciples protested saying, “This is a hard saying; who can understand it?” (Jn 6:60). When Lord Jesus explicitly emphasized His real presence in the Sacrament, it was written, “many of His disciples went back and walked with Him no more” (Jn 6:66)

The question of the real presence is of considerable importance in relation to the differences, which have emerged within Christianity since the time of the so-called ‘Reformation’. A particularly important witness to the early Christian understanding of this Sacrament is provided by the ‘Catechetical lectures’ of St. Cyril of Jerusalem. This series of 24 lectures of instruction on the beliefs and practices of the Christian Church, given at some point around 350 AD to those preparing for baptism, are an important witness to the ideas that prevailed in the Jerusalem Church around this point. It is clear that St. Cyril regarded the bread and wine as becoming the real body and blood of our Lord Jesus Christ:

“[Jesus Christ], by his own will, once changed water into wine at Cana of Galilee.

So why should we not believe that he can change wine into blood?

We should therefore have full assurance that we are sharing in the body and blood of Christ. For in the type of bread, his body is given to you, and in the type of wine, his blood is given to you, so that by partaking of the body and blood of Christ you may become of one body and one blood with Him.” (St. Cyril of Jerusalem). St. John of Damascus wrote the following about the question of how this transformation of the bread and wine takes place:

“And now you ask how the bread becomes the body of Christ, and the wine and the water become the blood of Christ. I shall tell you. The Holy Spirit comes upon them, and achieves things which surpass every word and thought Let it be enough for you to understand that this takes place by the Holy Spirit” (St. John of Damascus).

+ **Benefits of the Sacrament:**

- Abiding in Lord Jesus Christ: “He who eats My flesh and drinks My blood abides in Me, and I in him” (Jn 6:56). Consequently we bear the fruits of the spirit, “He who abides in Me, and I in him, bears much fruit; for without Me you can do nothing” (Jn 15:5)
- Obtaining Eternal Life: “Whoever eats My flesh and drinks My blood has eternal life, and I will raise him up at the last day. He who eats this bread will live forever” (Jn 6:54,58)
- Growth & Maintenance of Our Spiritual Life: “Unless you eat the flesh of the Son of Man and drink His blood, you have no life in you... For My flesh is food indeed, and My blood is drink indeed...” he who feeds on Me will live because of Me” (Jn 6:53,55,57) Salvation & Remission of Sins: “This is My blood of the new covenant, which is shed for many for the remission of sins” (Mt 26:28)
- Unification of Believers: “For we, being many, are one bread and one body; for we all partake of that one bread” (1 Cor 10:17)



+ **Consequences of Unworthy Communion:**

- St. Paul said, “Whoever eats this bread or drinks this cup of the Lord in an unworthy manner will be guilty of the body and blood of the Lord. But let a man examine himself, and so let him eat of that bread and drink of that cup. For he who eats and drinks in an unworthy manner eats and drinks judgment to himself, not discerning (recognizing clearly) the Lord’s body. For this reason many are weak and sick among you, and many sleep (die). For if we would judge ourselves, we would not be judged.” **(1 Cor 11:27-31)**

The Meaning of Worthiness:

- **Orthodox Faith:** The person who approaches the Eucharist must be an Orthodox Christian having no doubt concerning the bread & wine being the true body and precious blood of Lord Jesus Christ.
- **Repentance & Confession:** The person must be practicing the Sacrament of Repentance and Confession on regular basis as St. Paul said, “let a man examine himself” **(1 Cor 11:28)**
- **Reconciliation With Others:** Lord Jesus Christ said, “If you bring your gift to the altar, and there remember that your brother has something against you, leave your gift there before the altar, and go your way. First be reconciled to your brother, and then come offer your gift” **(Mt 5:23-24)**
- **True Worthiness is Feeling Unworthy:** St. Paul, the meek and humble apostle said, “I know nothing against myself, yet I am not justified by this” **(1 Cor 4:4)**
- **Obedying The Church Rules:** concerning food abstinence before communion, physical cleanliness, and early attendance of the liturgy.



+ **The Eucharist as a Sacrifice:**

The Orthodox Church believes and confesses that the Eucharist is a sacrifice and an offering to God in addition to being a Sacrament. The following supports this belief:

- The words of Lord Jesus Christ Himself, “This is My blood of the new covenant, which is shed for many” **(Mt 26:28; Mk 14:24)** - “This cup is the new covenant in My blood, which is shed for you” **(Lk 22:20)** - “This is My body which is broken for you” **(1 Cor 11:24)** - “This is my body which is given for you” **(Lk 22:19)**. Undoubtedly, the terms “broken body” and “shed blood” refer to a sacrifice.

- *The presence of an altar in the Church confirms that the Eucharist is a sacrifice. St. Paul said, "We have an altar from which those who serve the tabernacle (Jews) have no right to eat" (**Heb 13:10**). Isaiah the Prophet said, "In that day there will be an altar to the Lord in the midst of the land of Egypt" (**Is 19:19**), this is a specific prophecy about the the Coptic (Egyptian) Church which proves the presence of altars in the Christian era and consequently the presence of a sacrifice (the Eucharist).*
- *Malachi the Prophet prophesied about the New Testament offering saying, "I have no pleasure in you, says the Lord of hosts, nor will accept an offering from your hands. For from the rising of the sun even to its going down, My name shall be great among the nations, says the Lord of hosts" (**Mal 1:10-11**). This "pure offering" is nothing but the Eucharistic offering that Christians offer on their altars, for at which point in history did the Gentiles "in every place" offer an offering to the Lord?*
- *St. Paul said, "Observe Israel after the flesh: Are not those who eat of the sacrifices partakers of the altar? What am I saying then? That an idol is anything, or what is offered to idol is anything (else)? Rather, that the things which the Gentiles sacrifice they sacrifice to demons and not to God, and I do not want you to have fellowship with demons. You cannot drink the cup the Lord and the cup of demons; you cannot partake of the Lord's table and the table of demons" (**1 Cor 10:18-21**). The apostle is comparing the table (altar) of the Lord to the altar of the pagans upon which unacceptable demonic sacrifices were offered, which proves that the Eucharist that is offered on the Christian altar is indeed a sacrifice.*

+ **The Sacrifice of the Cross & the Sacrifice of the Eucharist:**

- *The Cross: The Holy Body & Precious Blood were offered visibly.*
- *The Eucharist: The Holy Body & Precious Blood are offered Sacramentally as bread & wine.*
- *The Cross: Offered by Lord Jesus Christ as the Chief High Priest.*
- *The Eucharist: Offered by the New Testament Priests (according to the order of Melchizedek).*
- *The Cross: The lamb (Lord Jesus Christ) was slain, His blood was shed, and He died.*
- *The Eucharist: No shedding of blood and no death. Hence is called "bloodless sacrifice."*
- *The Cross: Offered once on Good Friday.*
- *The Eucharist: Offered several times from it's institution till the second coming of the Lord.*

+ **FAQ:**

Q1: Why don't we allow Protestants to take communion in our Churches?

A1: The Didache or "the teaching of the 12 apostles" is a manuscript, which was used by 2nd century bishops and priests for the instruction of the catechumens. Many early Church Fathers have referenced it making this document relatively easy to date. It states "Let no one eat or drink or your Eucharist but those baptized in the name of the Lord; to this, too the saying of the Lord is applicable, "Do not give what is holy to the dogs" (**Mt 7:6**). St Paul forbade the Jews from taking communion in an unworthy manner. How can the Church allow a protestant, who denies the real presence of the Lord in the Eucharist, to take communion?

A servant is not greater than his master. If they persecuted Me, they will also persecute you. If they kept My word, they will keep yours also.” (Jn 15:20)

+ Lecture XII:

The Question of The Real Presence +

+ Definitions:

1. **Transubstantiation:** This term, associated with the Roman Catholic Church, is the change of the substance of bread and wine into the Body and Blood of Lord Jesus Christ occurring in the Eucharist while all that is accessible to the senses remain as before.

"Substance" here means what something is in itself. A hat's shape is not the hat itself, nor is its color the hat, nor is its size, nor its softness to the touch nor anything else about it perceptible to the senses. The hat itself (the "substance") has the shape, the 3 color, the size, the softness and the other appearances, but is distinct from them. While the appearances, which are referred to by the philosophical term accidents, are perceptible to the senses, the substance is not. Oriental and Eastern Orthodox Christians agree that the bread and wine truly and actually become the body and blood of Christ. They have in general refrained from philosophical speculation, and usually rely on the status of the doctrine as a "Mystery," something known by divine revelation that could not have been arrived at by reason without revelation. Accordingly, they prefer not to elaborate upon the details and remain firmly within Holy Tradition, than to say too much and possibly deviate from the truth. However, they do speak clearly of a "change" (in Greek *psstafio*) or "metousiosis" (*uetouoicnotg*) of the bread and wine. Met—Ousi—osis is the Greek form of the word Tran-substantia-tion. (From Wikipedia, the free Encyclopedia)

2. **Consubstantiation:** This view, especially associated with Martin Luther, attempts to describe the nature of the Eucharist in concrete metaphysical terms. It holds that the fundamental "substance" of the body and blood of the Lord are present alongside the substance of the bread and wine, which remain present. It asserts the simultaneous presence of four essences in the Eucharist: that of the consecrated bread, the Body of Lord Jesus Christ, the consecrated wine, and the Blood of Lord Jesus Christ; but it differs from what the Lutherans believe in that it does not assert a "local" presence of the Body and Blood in the sacramental bread and wine respectively.
3. **Memorialism or Real Absence:** This understanding of the nature of the Eucharist is especially associated with Zwingli. The Eucharist is nothing but a memorial of the suffering of the Lord, and not a sacrifice. The bread and wine are mere symbols of the Body and Blood.

+ Why Do We Believe in the Real Presence?

Generally speaking, there are three reasons why we believe in the real presence of Lord Jesus Christ in the Sacrament of the Eucharist:

- I) **Biblical Reasons**
- II) **Logical Reasons**
- III) **Historical Reasons**

+ **Biblical Reasons** +

1. Whenever our Lord Jesus Christ would speak symbolically and yet the Jews would understand His blessed words literally, St. John would point their mistake out:

- a) *"Jesus answered and said to them, 'Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up.' So the Jews answered and said to Him, 'It has taken forty-six years to build this temple, and will You raise it up in three days?' But He was speaking of the temple of His body."* **(Jn 2:19-21)**
- b) *"On the last day, that great day of the feast, Jesus stood and cried out, saying, 'If anyone thirsts, let him come to Me and drink. He who believes in Me, as the Scripture has said, out of his heart will flow rivers of living water.' But this He spoke concerning the Spirit, whom those believing in Him would receive."* **(Jn 7:37-39)**
- c) *"Then they said to Him, 'Who are you?' And Jesus said to them, 'Just as I have been saying to you from the beginning. I have many things to say and to judge concerning you, but he who sent Me is true; and I speak to the world those things which I heard from Him.' They did not understand that He spoke to them of the Father."* **(Jn 8:25-27)**

❖ Lord Jesus Christ said, *"The bread that I will give is My flesh, which I shall give for the life of the world"* **(Jn 6:51)** but *"The Jews therefore quarreled among themselves, saying, 'How can this Man give us His flesh to eat?'"* **(Jn 6:52)**

❖ Now, if Lord Jesus Christ was speaking symbolically and the Jews misunderstood Him why didn't St. John point their mistake out as he did previously? The fact that St. John didn't do that means that Lord Jesus Christ was indeed speaking literally.

❖ The reply of the Lord reinforces the fact that His words were literal, *"Most assuredly, I say to you, unless you eat the flesh of the Son of Man and drink His blood, you have no life in you... For My flesh is food indeed, and My blood is drink indeed"* **(Jn 6:53,55)**

2. When Lord Jesus said, *"Most assuredly, I say to you, unless you eat the flesh of the Son of Man and drink His blood, you have no life in you. Whoever eats My flesh and drinks My blood has eternal life, and I will raise him up at the last day. For My flesh is food indeed and My blood is drink indeed. He who eats My flesh and drink My blood abides in Me, and I in him"* **(Jn 6:53-56)**, many of His disciples took Him literally and said, *"This is a hard saying: who can understand it?"*

❖ Now our Lord Jesus Christ was fully aware that many of His disciples understood His words literally and were offended, He even said to them, *"Does this offend you?"* **(Jn 6:61)**. Moreover, St. John said, *"From that time many of His disciples went back and walked with no more"* **(Jn 6:66)**

- ❖ Obviously, if Lord Jesus Christ had only meant that they would eat His flesh and drink His blood figuratively or symbolically, He would have said so before they walked away for it is written that "He explained all things to His disciples" (Mk 4:34) But the Lord did not explain and let them go. Therefore, He meant His words literally and of course not visually or cannibalistically but miraculously and Sacramentally.
- ❖ Some people become confused by what Lord Jesus Christ said after the disciples complained. He said, "It is the Spirit who gives life; the flesh profits nothing. The words that I speak to you are spirit, and they are life" (**Jn 6:63**). They mistakenly think that this is proof that Lord Jesus Christ is saying that He only means that the disciples will eat His Flesh and drink His Blood spiritually and not literally. But it is illogical that the Lord would say that His Flesh "profit nothing" (useless) after saying that it gives life (**v 53**).
Rather, Lord Jesus Christ is not talking about His Flesh, but about their flesh. He is telling the unbelieving disciples that they cannot grasp or come to His blessed teaching on the Eucharist by their senses or their flesh which "profits nothing" for this purpose, only through faith or Spirit.
- 3. St. Paul said that our Lord said, "Take, eat; this is My body which is broken for you" (**1 Cor 11:24**). But we all know that the Body of our Lord was never broken, "when they came to Jesus and saw that He was already dead, they did not break His legs... these things were done that the Scripture should be fulfilled, No one of His bones shall be broken" (**Jn 19:33,36**)
- ❖ The fact that the Lord said that this is His Body "which is broken" affirms that it is not a symbol but rather the true body because if the bread were a mere symbol, then it shouldn't be broken for the body on the cross was never broken. (The symbol should match the thing symbolized)
- 4. Whenever the term "eating flesh" occurs in symbolically Holy Scripture, it refer to slander, hate and back stabbing:
 - a) "When the wicked came against me to eat up my flesh, my enemies and foes, they stumbled and fell." (**Ps 27:2**)
 - b) "You who hate good and love evil; Who strip the skin from My people, and the flesh from their bones; Who also eat the flesh of y people, flay their skin from them." (**Mic 3:2-3**)
 - c) "If you bite and devour one another, beware lest you be consumed by one another." (**Gal 5:15**)
- ❖ If we interpret the Lord's words about eating His Flesh and drinking His Blood symbolically, we fall in the worst interpretation.
- 5. St. Paul said, "He who eats and drinks in an unworthy manner eats and drinks judgment to himself, not discerning the Lord's body" (**1 Cor 11:29**).
 - ❖ To discern means, "To perceive or recognize clearly. To distinguish" (Webster's New World Dictionary).
 - ❖ This verse clearly proves the transformation of the bread to the real body of the Lord and whoever takes communion without this faith eats and drinks judgment to himself.

6. The words of the Lord about this Sacrament are straightforward and clear:

- a) *“And as they were eating, Jesus took bread, blessed it and broke it, and gave it to the disciples and said, ‘Take, eat; this is My body.’ Then He took the cup, and gave thanks, and gave it to them, saying, ‘Drink from it, all of you. For this is My blood of the new covenant, which is shed for many for the remission of sins” (Mt 26:26-28)*
- b) *“And as they were eating, Jesus took bread, blessed it and broke it, and gave it to them and said, ‘Take, eat; this is My body.’ Then He took the cup, and when He had given thanks He gave it to them, and they all drank from it. And He said to them, ‘This is My blood of the new covenant, which is shed for many” (Mk 14:22-24)*
- c) *“And He took bread, gave thanks and broke it, and gave it to them, saying ‘This is My body which is given for you; do this in remembrance of Me.’ Likewise He also took the cup after supper, saying, ‘This cup is the new covenant in My blood, which is shed for you” (Lk 22:29-20)*

❖ Lord Jesus Christ said clearly, *“This is My Body — This is My Blood”* who can tell Him *“No it is not!”* Indeed, *“Let God be true but every man a liar” (Rom 3:4)*

7. St. Paul said, *“I speak as to wise men; judge for yourselves what I say. The cup of blessing which we bless, is it not the communion of the blood of Christ? The bread which we break, is it not the communion of the body of Christ?” (1 Cor 10:15-16)*

❖ How can we possibly have communion with the Body and Blood of Lord Jesus Christ if the bread and wine were mere symbols?

+ Logical Reasons +

- 1. The words of Lord Jesus Christ about this Sacrament constitute a testimony, *“This is My Body, This is My Blood”* also the Lord testified that His Body is food indeed and His Blood is drink indeed (Jn 6:56).
 - ❖ A testimony must be literal without figurative or symbolic language.
- 2. The words of Lord Jesus Christ about this Sacrament constitute a covenant, *“This cup is the new covenant” (Lk 22:20) — “Whoever eats My flesh and drinks My blood has eternal life” (Jn 6:54)*9 The words of a covenant must be literal. (Would you write a contract in symbolic words?)
- 3. Symbols and analogies must have a kind of resemblance to what they symbolize. For example, the brazen serpent and the crucifixion of the Lord, Jonah in the belly of the fish and the burial of the Lord, the story of offering Isaac the beloved son of his Father, and the offering of the only Begotten Son, etc.
 - ❖ The bread, which is broken, cannot be a symbol of the intact body of our Lord. Notice that because the Passover lamb was a symbol of the Lord, no bone was broken from it (Ex 12:46)
- 4. The saving spiritual blessings that are associated with this Sacrament (Jn 6: 51-59) cannot be attributed to eating mere bread unless this bread is truly transformed into the true body of the Savior.
- 5. The severe punishment that reach death (1 Cor 11:31) cannot be associated with eating mere bread and drinking mere wine unless they are truly transformed to the Body and Blood of Lord Jesus Christ.
- 6. It is written about the cup that it is for the remission of sins (Mt 26:26-27). The only way this can be true is for the mixture in this cup to be transformed to the real blood of the Savior for *“without shedding of blood there is no remission” (Heb 9:22)*

+ Historical Reasons +

1. All apostolic Churches universally agree about the real presence of the Lord in the Sacrament of the Eucharist in spite of their disagreements on many other issues.
2. All Eastern and Western Church Fathers have agreed, without exception, that the words of the Lord about this Holy Sacrament are to be understood literally.
3. Martin Luther himself could not dare to deny the presence of the Lord in the Eucharist (although his view was still heretical) and it wasn't until later that Zwingli came up with the heresy of real absence which most of the Protestants believe today.

+ FAQ:

Q: What are the differences with the Roman Catholic Church concerning the Eucharist?

A: There are no differences concerning the belief that the Eucharist is the true Body and Blood of Lord Jesus Christ. Nevertheless, there are some differences concerning the administration of the Sacrament:

- a) They consecrate unleavened bread (wafers) even though the very word “artos”, which is used in the Greek text of the gospel in the narration on the institution of the Sacrament, signifies precisely leavened, fermented, risen bread.
- b) They forbid infants and small children from taking communion. - Lord Jesus Christ said about the children, “Let the little children come to Me, and do not forbid them; for of such is the kingdom of heaven” (Mt 19:14). In fact the little children are the most worthy individuals to take communion and the adults need to take them as examples for indeed, “unless you are converted and become as little children, you will by no means enter the kingdom of heaven” (Mt 18:3)
- c) They allow people to partake of the Holy Body without partaking of the Holy Blood. - Lord Jesus Christ administered both His Body and His Blood to His disciples and He said about the cup “Drink from it, all of you” (Mt 26:27). He also said, “Unless you eat the flesh of the Son of Man and drink His blood, you have no life in you. Whoever eats My flesh and drinks My blood has eternal life” (Jn 6:53-54). St. Paul said, “As often as you eat this bread and drink this cup, you proclaim the Lord's death till He comes” (1 Cor 11:26) — “Let a man examine himself, and so let him eat of the bread and drink of that cup” (1 Cor 11:28).
- d) When communion of the laity takes place at the Roman Mass, the priest, besides the main unleavened wafer, from which he himself communes, consecrates others as well, little ones, one for each communicant. This custom contradicts the very concept of the unity of the Eucharistic Sacrifice. Communion from ‘one bread’ has, according to the teaching of the word of God, a profound significance, “For we, being many, are one bread and one body; for we all partake of that one bread.” (1 Cor 10:17)

Q6: St. Paul said, “Purge out the old leaven, that you may be a new lump, since you truly are unleavened. For indeed Christ, our Passover was sacrificed for us” (1 Cor 5:7). Is the apostle talking about the consecrating unleavened bread in the Eucharist?

A6: Leaven is a symbol of sin and evil, and St. Paul says in the verse that follows, “Let us keep the feast, not with old leaven, nor with the leaven of malice and wickedness, but with the unleavened bread of sincerity and truth” (1 Cor 5:8). St. Paul is not talking about the Eucharist but he is talking about the sinner that he mentioned in the beginning of this chapter about whom he also said, “a little leaven leavens the whole lump” (1 Cor 5:6). We can mention here that since the leaven symbolizes sin and our Lord indeed carried our sins, therefore it is more fitting to consecrate leavened bread in the Eucharist.

* This lecture is adapted from ‘The Sacraments of The Church’ By Archdeacon Habib Guirgess.

“Around the throne were twenty-four thrones, and on the thrones I saw twenty-four elders [priests] sitting, clothed in white robes; and they had crowns of gold on their heads” (Rev 4:4)

+ **Lecture II: The Sacrament of Priesthood** +

The Sacrament of Priesthood is the Holy Sacrament by which the Bishop lays his hand on the elected candidate in order for the Holy Spirit to descend on this person to grant him one of the priestly ranks. As a result, the ordained person is granted the authority to perform the ministry of the Church, whether the Holy Sacraments, teaching or others. This process is called “Laying of hands” or “Ordination.”

+ **Institution of The Sacrament:**

Lord Jesus Christ instituted this Sacrament when He chose the twelve of His followers and consecrated them for ministry, “He called His disciples to Him, and from them He chose twelve whom He also named apostles” (Lk 6:13). He gave them the authority of absolution and binding, “He breathed on them, and said to them, ‘Receive the Holy Spirit’. If you forgive the sins of any, they are forgiven them; if you retain the sins of any, they are retained” (Jn 20:22-23). Notice that this took place before the Pentecost and the gift of the Holy Spirit here is the gift of ordination. Only to them He said, “Go therefore and make disciples of all the nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and the Son and of the Holy Spirit” (Mt 28:19) and only to them He delivered the mystery of His Body and Blood (The Eucharist)

+ **Honor of Priesthood:**

St. Paul said, “No man takes this honor to himself, but he who is called by God” (Heb 5:4) and “Let the elders [priests] who rule well be counted worthy of double honor” (I Tim 5:17), for the Priesthood is:

a) **A divine choice, call and appointment:**

- *Then He appointed twelve, that they might be with Him and that He might send them out to preach and to have power to heal sicknesses and to cast out demons.” (Mk 3:13-15)*
- *“And when it was day, He called His disciples to Himself; and from them He chose twelve whom He also named apostles.” (Lk 6:12-13)*
- *“You did not choose Me, but I chose you and appointed you that you should go and bear fruit and that*
- *“After these things the Lord appointed seventy others also, and sent them two by two before His face into every city and place where He Himself was about to go.” (Lk 10:1)*
- *“As they ministered to the Lord and fasted, the Holy Spirit said, ‘Now separate to Me Barnabas and Saul for the work to which I have called them.’ Then, having fasted and prayed, and laid hands on them, they sent them away.” (Acts 13:2-3)*

b) **Faithfulness and Stewardship:**

- *“Who then is that faithful and wise steward, whom his master will make ruler over his household, to give them their portion in due season? Blessed is that servant whom his master will find so doing he comes.” (Lk 12:42-43)*
- *“Let a man so consider us, as servants of Christ and stewards of the mysteries [Sacraments] of God. Moreover it is required in stewards that one be found faithful” (1 Cor 4:1-2)*

c) **Consecration or Sanctification:**

- *Lord Jesus Christ said, “for their sakes I sanctify Myself, that they also may be sanctified by the truth” (Jn 17:19). To sanctify means to consecrate; our Lord has consecrated Himself for the ministry and redemption. Likewise, all ranks of the Priesthood are consecrated for the ministry according to the example of Lord Jesus Christ, the Great High Priest.*

+ The Order of Deacons +

1. Epsaltos (Hymnist, Cantor):

The work of the Epsaltos is obvious from his name that is to learn and sing Church hymns and praises. This rank is mentioned in some of the early Church canons, "Chanters also must be blessed by the Bishop". Children are usually ordained in this rank as the Psalm says, "Out of the mouth of babes and infants You have ordained strength" (Ps 8:2), the wisdom of children's ordination is attaching them to the Church in order to grow up being nourished by the Orthodox faith and rites, so that they become steadfast in the faith, clinging to it with a high level of spirituality and holiness, as the Psalm says, "But I am like a green olive tree in the house of God I will praise You forever" (Ps 52:8-9)

2. Anagnostis (Reader, Lector):

His work is the daily readings in Church especially the Holy Epistles; he must read without mistakes so that the congregation may understand what is read. After the Commemoration of the Saints, readers recite the names of the Patriarchs who passed away in the Lord as the deacon says, "Let those who read recite the names of our fathers the Patriarchs who have fallen asleep; O Lord repose their souls and forgive us our sins". Readers also can give sermons to the congregation as mentioned in the rite of their ordination, "Lord show Your face to Your servant standing before You to know by Your Holy Words to preach Your laws to Your people, teach them Your pure words for their rescue and salvation", this is done by the permission from the Bishop or Priest. Readers are required to receive the Church Psalmody (Praises) and receipt it with the chorus during Liturgy and other occasions.

3. Epideacon (Sub-deacon):

His work is to prevent heretics and false teachers from entering the Church, to light the Church's lamps, to maintain the books of the Church, to prepare the censor, to organize the worshipers and to help the deacon and replace him if necessary. These responsibilities are added to the previous ones of the reader.

4. Deacon (Servant):

His work is to recite all the liturgical responses. In the past no one was allowed to enter to the Sanctuary except the Bishop, Priest and the Deacon or Archdeacon, also kings who were believers and anointed by Chrism. The deacon may carry the chalice and give the congregation from the precious blood of the Lord during communion. He reads the Holy Gospel of the Liturgy and may teach or preach by the permission of the Bishop or Priest. The deacon helps the priest in the service by visiting the congregation, widows and orphans, sick, etc. If he was ordained before marriage, he does not marry. If he had a wife and was ordained then his wife died, he remains without marriage like the case of Priests. If he elects to marry, he loses his rank.

5. Archdeacon (Leader of Deacons):

The Archdeacon leads all the ranks of deacons, manages their needs, and specifies their deeds.

❖ Qualifications of Deacons:

- St. Paul said, "Deacons must be reverent, not double-tongued, not given to much wine, not greedy for money, holding the mystery of faith with a pure conscience. But let these also first be proved; then let them serve as deacons, being found blameless... Let deacons be the husbands of one wife, ruling their children and their own houses well." (1 Tim 3:8-9,12)
- The twelve apostles set the criteria of ordination of the seven deacons as being "of good reputation, full of the Holy Spirit and wisdom" (Acts 6:3). Although this rank is the smallest of the priestly ranks, St. Paul praised it saying, "Those who have served well as deacons obtain for themselves a good standing and great boldness in the faith which is in Christ Jesus" (1 Tim 3:13). It is also noteworthy to mention that the first Christian martyr was St. Steven the deacon who saw heaven opened and Lord Jesus standing at the right hand of God (Acts 7:56)

+ The Order of Priests +

1. Priest, Elder, Presbyter:

This is the first and essential priestly rank. The priest has the right to administer all the church Sacraments except the laying of hands and ordination, which reserved to the Bishop or someone above him. He teaches the people the word of God, explains to them the dogmas and rites, and leads them to the way of righteousness "For the lips of a priest should keep knowledge, and people should seek the law from his mouth; for he is the messenger of the Lord of hosts." (Mal 2:7) He is a father who pastors his children compassionately, visits them with tenderness care and love, as he is zealous for their salvation. He humbly serves them as Lord Jesus washed the feet of His disciples.

2. Hegomen, Senior Priest, Archpriest:

This is only a promotional rank from a priest and is not considered as a new ordination. If there were more than one priest serving in the same Church, the oldest in ordination or the most active and knowledgeable is promoted to the rank of hegomen. The rest of the priests submit to him and consider him the primary responsible person in the Church.

3. Khoori-Episcopos (Bishop of a village):

This rank came to existence by the end of the third century in Asia Minor when the dioceses extended and their division to smaller ones was not preferred. Members of the Nicene Council included 15 Khoori-Episcopos from Asia Minor and Syria. This rank disappeared from our Coptic Church and was revived by H.H. Pope Shenouda III when His Holiness ordained several monks as Khoori-Episcopos in order to assist some Bishops and Metropolitans in the service of their wide dioceses. His Holiness promoted most of them later on to general Bishops or Bishops of Dioceses. This rank is closer to the Bishopric rank for the candidate is a monk, holds the title of "Anba", his turban is very similar to the Bishop's, has the authority to ordain the various ranks of Deacons, is a member of the Holy synod, and his name is mentioned like the Bishop in all liturgical prayers and hymns.

+ The Order of Bishops +

1. Bishop, Overseer, Episcopos:

This is the highest rank of the Priesthood. Bishops are distinguished from Priests by having the perfection of the Priesthood and the authority to lay hands and ordain all the diaconry and priestly ranks in their dioceses.

2. Metropolitan (Bishop of a large city):

This is a promotional rank from the Bishop, and the Metropolitan is mentioned before the Bishop in all the Church rites.

3. Patriarch, Pope, Archbishop:

The Patriarch is the highest rank in the Bishopric level and has the greatest ruling of Priesthood; he is the leader of the Church, Bishops and Metropolitans. The Patriarch is the successor of our fathers the Apostles and is the symbol of the unity of the Church. He has the right to ordain Bishops (at least one Bishop accompany him) and promote them to Metropolitans. He also has the right to make the Holy oil (Mayron). He heads the sessions of the Holy Synod, which is the highest authority in the Church.

❖ Qualification of Bishops:

- St. Paul said, “A bishop must be blameless, as a steward of God, not self-willed, not quick-tempered, not given to wine, not violent, not greedy for money, but hospitable, a lover of what is good, sober-minded, just, holy, self-controlled, holding fast the faithful word as he has been taught, that he may be able, by sound doctrine, both to exhort and convict those who contradict.” (Titus 1:7-9)
- “A bishop then must be blameless, the husband of one wife, temperate, sober-minded, of good behavior, hospitable, able to teach; not given to wine, not violent, not greedy for money, but gentle, not quarrelsome, not covetous. .. not a novice, lest being puffed up with pride he fall into the same condemnation as the devil. Moreover he must have a good testimony among those who are outside, lest he fall into reproach and the snare of the devil.” (1 Tim 3:2-3,6-7)

Q: The Holy Bible said that the Bishop should be “the husband of one wife” (1 Tim 3:2). Why then do we ordain the Bishops from the celibate monks?

A: First of all, “we” don’t ordain anybody; the Pope does, “we” merely recommend the ordination. Secondly, St. John Chrysostom said, “The apostle did not place this order as a basis that he (the Bishop) must be a husband of a wife, but he forbids from this rank the individual who married more than one wife, as he wanted to choose the most pure and modest, but since the door of celibacy and monasticism is opened so the Bishops are ordained from the celibate monks who never married at all.” Moreover, The Holy Book of Revelation (the only Prophetic Book of the New Testament) called the Bishops “Angels” and our Lord said that the angels “neither man’y nor are given in marriage” (Mt 22:30). In the Nicene Council 325 AD, a decision was made that priests must be married because of the nature of their service since they enter houses and solve family problems. Nevertheless, if the priest is widowed, he does not remarry another woman since he is the father of all women and a father cannot marry one of his daughters.

+ Lord Jesus Christ & The Ranks of Priesthood +

Our Lord Jesus Christ practiced certain services that became the essence of the Church ranks:

- a) **The Epsaltos:** The person who holds this rank is required to learn and sing the Church hymns. Lord Jesus Christ sung a hymn with His disciples before going to Gethsemane, “And when they had sung a hymn, they went out to the Mount of Olives” (Mt 26:30)
- b) **The Anagnostis:** The most important work of this rank is reading the Holy Scriptures in Church during the Liturgy. Our Lord practiced the work of the reader when He went in the synagogue and stood up to read (Lk 4:16)
- c) **The Epideacon:** The most important work is keeping the Church organized. The Lord did the same when He drove out all those who bought and sold in the temple (Mt 21:12)
- d) **The Deacon:** One of the duties of the Deacon is to pour water for the priest to wash his hands upon the start of the Mass. Our Lord poured water into a basin and washed the disciples’ feet (Jn 13:5)
- e) **The Priest:** The main work of the priest is to sanctify the bread and wine during the Holy Liturgy and to give communion to the congregation. The Lord did the same on Covenant Thursday (Mk 14:22-26)

1) The Hegomen: The role of the Hegomen is to provide for the Church services. It is obvious that our Lord did the same for when He said to Judas “What you do, do quickly” (Jn 13:27) the disciples thought that since Judas had the money box, the Lord had asked him to buy what they need for the feast or to give to the poor (Jn 13:29)

g) The Bishop: The bishop is the shepherd of the flock. St. Peter refers to Lord Jesus as the shepherd and overseer of our souls (1 Pet 2:25) and the Lord said about Himself, “I am the good Shepherd” (Jn 10:14)
h) The Patriarch: Only the Pope can ordain Bishops and our Lord breathed on His apostles and gave them the authority to bind and loose sins (Jn 20:22-23)

Therefore, we find Lord Jesus Christ practicing most of the priestly ranks despite their variation so that every person may find in Him a good example to follow and to know that however small his rank may seem it is not lowly since the Lord Himself practiced and blessed it.

* This lecture 15 adapted from ‘The Sacrament of Priesthood’ by H.G. Bishop Mettaous.



*“But to you who fear My name The Sun of Righteousness shall arise with healing in His wings.”
(Mal 4:2)*

+ Lecture XVHI: The Sacrament of the Anointing of the Sick +

There are two Sacraments for ‘healing’; one for spiritual illness, which is the Sacrament of Repentance & Confession, the other for physical and psychological illness, which is the Sacrament of the Anointing of the Sick.

+ Institution of The Sacrament:

We do not know the exact time or occasion when our Lord instituted this Sacrament, which is no surprise for there are many things that the Lord did that were not written one by one (Jn 21:25), but we know that the Lord said:

- *“Heal the sick, cleanse the leper.” (Mt 10:8)*
- *“Whatever city you enter, and they received youheal the sick who are there.” (Lk 10:8-9)*
We also know that the disciples:
“Anointed with oil many who were sick, and healed them.” (Mk 6:13). It is understood that the apostles, having been sent by the Lord, were instructed to do so.

St. James also said:

- *“Is anyone among you sick? Let him call for the elders (priests) of the church, and let them pray over him, anointing him with oil in the name of the Lord. And the prayer of faith will save the sick, and the Lord will raise him up. And if he has committed sins, he will be forgiven. Confess your trespasses to one another, and pray for one another, that you may be healed.” (Jam 5:14-16)*

Here St. James is talking about both the Sacraments of Confession and Anointing of the Sick. This is not an ordinary means of healing sickness because it is administered by the priests and not by any person. Since the apostles did not preach their own gospel but delivered to us what they had previously received from the Lord, Therefore, St. James must have received this teaching directly from the Lord.

❖ FAQ:

Q1: *Why do people sometimes receive this Sacrament and yet are not healed?*

A1: *It could be because of their lack of faith, “He did not do many mighty works there because of their unbelief” (Mt 13:58) or it could be that God in His wisdom sees that this illness is beneficial to the person’s spiritual life as the case with St. Paul who prayed three times to be healed but God said to him, “My strength is made perfect in weakness” (2 Cor 12:9). We need to understand that in this Sacrament we do not dictate to God what to do but rather ask for his mercies.*

Q2: *Why does the Church perform this Sacrament to the whole congregation on the last Friday of the Lent?*

A2: *During the Holy Week of Pascha, the Church does not perform this Sacrament and therefore performs it and anoints the entire congregation on the last Friday of the Lent. Moreover, many are weak from fasting and this anointing helps them to continue with the scheduled prayers and food abstinence of the Pascha.*

* This lecture is adapted from, ‘The Church Sacraments ’ by Archdeacon Habib Guirgess.

“It is not good that man should be alone; I will make him a helper comparable to him.” (Gen 2:18)

+ Lecture XIX: The Sacrament of Matrimony +

Marriage is and has been a universal practice for almost every civilized culture throughout history, yet it is considered to be a Sacrament in the Orthodox Church. A Sacrament is a visible form of an invisible grace, it's a mystery, an open door through which mankind passes from the realm of the physical and earthly, into the reality of the spiritual and heavenly — the realm of communion with God. A Sacrament is seen through the context of created reality (for example, wine and bread in the Eucharist, water in Baptism, and oil in Confirmation, etc. ..). This created reality is then projected into the Kingdom of God and transformed into a higher reality, which belongs to the spiritual realm. As a result of Lord Jesus Christ's work of redemption, marriage is raised to a new level that transcends human procreation and legal contracts.

Marriage is, on one level, a created reality, which is indeed a universal practice. Men and women are attracted to each other, fall in love, and marry. But this created reality of marriage can be assumed into the Kingdom of God and sanctified. When a man and a woman come to the Church to be married, they are experiencing the transfiguration of their earthly marriage into the reality of the Kingdom of God. In the Holy Gospel according to St. John 2:1-11, we read about Lord Jesus Christ attending a wedding ceremony in Cana of Galilee. In being at this wedding and in performing His first miracle there, Lord Jesus Christ forever blesses marriage and sets it apart as “sanctified” way of life. This first miracle performed by the Lord at the wedding of Cana of Galilee is also symbolic; the transformation of water into wine is symbolic of the Sacramental transformation of the earthly reality of marriage into something heavenly and spiritual. (Adapted from an article by Fr. John Meyendorff)

Marriage, as a Sacrament, belongs to an entirely different order than the mere union of man and woman through civil contract. It basically regards a husband and wife as symbols of another marriage; namely, the marriage of Lord Jesus and the Church:

- *“Wives, submit to your own husbands, as to the Lord — therefore, just as the church is subject to Christ, so let the wives be to their own husbands in everything.” (Eph 5:22,24)*
- *“Husbands, love your wives, just as Christ also loved the church and gave Himself for it so husbands ought to love their own wives as their own bodies; he who loves his wife loves himself. For no one ever hated his own flesh, but nourishes and cherishes it, just as the Lord does the church.” (Eph 5:25,28-29)*

❖ Institution of the Sacrament:

Holy Scripture does not explicitly mention when our Lord instituted this Sacrament. Nevertheless, some fathers have said that He instituted it when He attended and blessed the wedding at Cana of Galilee (Jn 2:1—11) others have said that the Lord instituted it during His discussion with the Pharisees about divorce when He said, *“What God has joined together, let no man separate.” (Mt 19:6)*

- ❖ *In any case, St. Paul explicitly calls marriage “a great mystery [Sacrament]” (Eph 5:32)*

+ **Characteristics of an Orthodox Marriage:**

- No mixed marriages: “Do not be equally yoked together with unbelievers. For what fellowship has righteousness with lawlessness? And what communion has light with darkness? And what accord has Christ with Belial? Or what part has a believer with an unbeliever? And what agreement has the temple of God with idols? For you are the temple of the living God.” (2 Cor 6:14-16)
- Monogamy: “Let each man have his own wife, and let each woman have her own husband.” (1 Cor 7:2)
- Divorce is allowed only for sexual immorality reasons, “Whoever divorces his wife, except for sexual immorality and marries another, commits adultery; and whoever marries her who is divorced commits adultery” (Mt 19:9)



+ **The Goal of an Orthodox Marriage:**

Very often couples get married for the purpose of filling certain needs that they have in their own personal lives. Therefore, they come to marriage expecting happiness, emotional well-being, personal satisfaction without even having to work for them. When they don't get these things, they feel cheated or blame their spouse. As Orthodox Christians, we approach marriage very differently. The goal of marriage is not the fulfillment of one's needs; rather, the ultimate goal of marriage is heaven.

+ **FAQ:**

Q1: St. Paul said, “*The unbelieving husband is sanctified by the wife, and the unbelieving wife is sanctified by the husband*” (1 Cor 7:14) Is St. Paul permitting the marriage to unbelievers?

A1: St. Paul is talking to people who believed and were already married yet their spouses did not accept the faith. He said before the above verse, “If any brother has a wife who does not believe, and she is willing to live with him, let him not divorce her. And a woman who has a husband who does not believe, if he is willing to live with her, let her not divorce him” (1 Cor 7:12-13) then he said, “if the unbeliever departs, let him depart; a brother or a sister is not under bondage in such cases” (1 Cor 7:15)

This lecture is adapted from 'The Church Sacraments' by Habib Guirgess.

Resources for Marriage :

1. *“Before You Say I Do”* - by H. Norman Wright
2. *“Fire Proof Your Marriage” (Couples Kit)* — by Jennifer Dion
3. On Marriage and Family Life Paperback by [Saint John Chrysostom](#)
4. <http://www.focusonthefamily.ca/marriage/pre-marriage/7-essential-conversations-to-have-with-your-future-spouse>
5. <http://www.smalley.cc/>
6. <http://www.5lovelanguages.com/>



“How shall we escape if we neglect so great a salvation.” (Heb 2:3)

+ **Lecture VIII: Salvation in The Orthodox Concept** +

I) The Blood of our Lord Jesus Christ & Salvation:

Salvation is only available through the blood of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ, “without shedding of blood there is no remission” (Heb 9:22). The Passover lamb was a symbol of our Lord, “For indeed Christ, our Passover, was sacrificed for us” (1Cor 5:7). Through the blood of the lamb, the Israelites were saved from death, “Now the blood shall be a sign for you on the houses where you are, and when I see the blood, I will pass over you and the plague shall not be on you to destroy you when I strike the land of Egypt” (Ex 12:13). Through this precious blood sins are remitted and we enter in a new covenant with God, “This is My blood of the new covenant which is shed for many for the remission of sins” (Mt 26:28).

+ **Some Biblical References** +

- “Shepherd the Church of God which He purchased with His own blood.” (Acts 20:28)
- “Having now been justified by His blood, we shall be saved from wrath through Him.” (Rom 5:9)
- “In Him we have redemption through His blood.” (Eph 1:7) & (Col 1:14)
- “In Christ Jesus you who once were far off have been made near by the blood of Christ.” (Eph 2:13)
- “Having made peace through the blood of His cross.” (Col 1:20)
- “Not with the blood of goats and calves, but with His own blood He entered the most Holy place once for all, having obtained eternal redemption.” (Heb 9:12)
- “. . .How much more shall the blood of Christ, who through the eternal spirit offered Himself without spot to God, purge your conscience from dead works to serve the living God.” (Heb 9:14)
- “Therefore brethren having boldness to enter the Holiest by the blood of Jesus.” (Heb 10:19)
- “Of how much worse punishment, do you suppose, will be thought worthy who has trampled the son of God underfoot, counted the blood of the covenant by which he was sanctified a common thing, and insulted the Spirit of grace?” (Heb 10:29)
- “. . .To Jesus the Mediator of the new covenant, and to the blood of sprinkling that speaks better things than that of Abel” (Heb 12:24)

The blood of our Lord Jesus Christ speaks better things than that of Abel because the blood of Abel was seeking revenge as God said to Cain, “The voice of your brother’s blood cries out to Me from the ground” (Gen 4:10). On the other hand, the blood of Lord Jesus Christ **was seeking forgiveness of sins**,

“Father, forgive them for they do not know what they do.” (Lk 23:34).

- “Now may the God of peace through the blood of the everlasting covenant, make you complete in every good work to do His will.” (Heb 13:20-21)
- “You were not redeemed with corruptible things ...but with the precious blood of Christ as of a lamb without blemish and without spot.” (1Pet 1:18-19)

- *“There are three that bear witness on earth: the Spirit, the water, and the blood; and these three agree as one.” (1Jn 5:8)*
- *The blood of Jesus Christ His Son cleanses us from all sin.” (1Jn 1:7)*
- *“... To Him who loved us and washed us from our sins in His own blood...” (Rev 1:5)*
- *.. You were slain, and have redeemed us to God by Your blood ...” (Rev 5:9)*
- *“These are the ones who came out of the great tribulation, and washed their robes and made them white in the blood of the lamb.” (Rev 7:14)*
- *"And they over came him by the blood of the lamb ...” (Rev 12:11)*

+ **Application of the above concept:**

1. The sins of the people in the Old Testament were not forgiven until the day of the crucifixion of our Lord Jesus Christ. All the sins of the Old Testament were merely “put away” as Nathan the Prophet said to King David, “The Lord also has put away your sin; you shall not die” (**2Sam 12:13**). He didn’t say ‘has forgiven your sin’ because “without shedding of blood there is no remission” (**Heb 9:22**). Hence, the Paradise was closed in front all the righteous people of the Old Testament until the day when our Lord Jesus Christ shed His ‘Blood on the cross and sins were remitted. The term “put away” means that the sin is transferred from one’s account to the account of the Savior.
2. When our Lord said to the paralytic “your sins are forgiven you” (**Lk 5:20**), He merely gave him a promise of forgiveness or a check so to speak, which would be cashed on the cross. This applies to all the instances where forgiveness and salvation were mentioned before the crucifixion (the sinful woman, the tax collector, Zacchaeus, and others. . .).

+ **Conditions for Salvation:**

Our Lord said that His blood is shed for **many** (Mt 26:28) but in reality only few are saved (Mt 7:13-14).

❖ This sad reality is due to the fact that there are certain conditions (prerequisites) for Salvation:

1. Faith.
2. Saving Sacraments:
 - a) Baptism.
 - b) Confirmation.
 - c) Repentance & Confession.
 - d) Eucharist.
3. Good Works.

❖ Each of these conditions will be discussed separately after we clarify certain points:

1. Baptism, Confirmation and Eucharist don’t apply to the people of the Old Testament because they acquire their saving efficacy from the blood of our Lord and the work of the Holy Spirit, which pertains to the New Testament. Nevertheless, the people of the Old Testament had symbols of these Sacraments like Circumcision being symbolic for Baptism (Col 2:11-12).
2. The above conditions for salvation apply to normal responsible adults. Whenever these conditions are mentioned, people come up with all sorts of scenarios to question them. For instance, mentally challenged individuals and infants don’t possess the intellectual ability to understand and believe and therefore the condition of faith doesn’t apply to them.
3. The Sacrament of the Priesthood administers to us the saving Sacraments and therefore plays a major role in our salvation and even though we don’t have to become priests to be saved, we do need them for our salvation as “stewards of the mysteries of God” (1Cor 4:1).

❖ **Salvation is the story of the whole life:**

St. Paul said that, “The message of the cross is foolishness to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God” (**1Cor 1:18**). Salvation in the Orthodox concept is seen as comprehending all of life; it is not a historical event that took place during a moment in the past. As the subject of salvation is addressed in Holy Scripture, the Orthodox Christian would see it in at least three aspects:

- a) I believe that I have been saved, having put on our Lord Jesus Christ in baptism.
- b) I believe that I am being saved, growing in our Lord Jesus Christ through the sacramental life of the Church.
- c) I believe that I will be saved, by God’s mercy in the Last Day of Judgment.

The story of salvation starts by faith, repentance and baptism, “He who believes and is baptized will be saved” (**Mk 16:16**), “Repent, and let everyone of you be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins” (Acts 2:38), this remission includes the original sin as well as all actual sins committed before baptism. Baptism provides us with salvation, forgiveness and regeneration. In baptism we are buried with our Lord Jesus Christ (**Col 2:12**), we die and rise with Him in the newness of life (**Rom 6:4**), “Knowing this, that our old man was crucified with Him, that the body of sin might be done away with, that we should no longer be slaves of sin” (**Rom 6:6**). Through baptism, we become children of God and members of His body (the Church). Moreover, St. Paul said, “As many of you as were baptized into Christ have put on Christ” (**Gal 3:27**).

In the Sacrament of Confirmation, we receive the gift of the Holy Spirit, “you have an anointing from the Holy One” (**1Jn 2:20**), and we become a temple of the Holy Spirit, “do you not know that your body is the temple of the Holy Spirit who is in you, whom you have from God” (**1Cor 6:19**). As a result of our response to the work of the Holy Spirit within us, we grow spiritually and bear the fruits of the Spirit (**Gal 5:22-23**).

Unfortunately, we still sin after being baptized and confirmed, “If we say that we have no sin, we deceive ourselves, and the truth is not in us” (**1Jn 1:18**). Even though our nature was renewed, we did not become infallible. The nature we receive in baptism is pure, yet liable to sin, as was Adam’s nature before the fall. The gift of regeneration that we receive in baptism does not cancel the gift of free will.

Nevertheless, there is a difference between people who sin without being baptized, while living the life of wickedness and those who sin after baptism. The later have the Holy Spirit to rebuke and lead them to repentance, sin is temporary unless a person, with his/her free will, decides to reject repentance insulting the spirit of grace (**Heb 10:29**) and thus blasphemes against the Holy Spirit (**Lk 12:10**).

Through repentance and confession we are being saved, “Unless you repent you will all likewise perish” (**Lk 13:3, 5**), “If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness” (**1Jn 1: 9**). Additionally, we obtain salvation during Holy Eucharist, as the priest says in the Divine Liturgy, “.. given for us salvation, remission of sins and eternal life to those who partake of it”, “whoever eats My flesh and drinks My blood has eternal life” (**Jn 6:54**).

Our life on earth is a test of our faith, “Now for a little while, if need be, you have been grieved by various trials, that the genuineness of your faith, being much more precious than gold that perishes, though it is tested by fire, may be found to praise, honor, and glory at the revelation of Jesus Christ” (**1Pet 1:6—7**). Indeed, “We must through many tribulations enter the kingdom of God” (**Acts 14:22**). Moreover, we are subject to spiritual warfare, “we do not wrestle against flesh and blood, but against principalities, against powers, against the rulers of the darkness of this age, against spiritual hosts of wickedness in the heavenly places” (Eph 6:12), “Be sober, be vigilant; because your adversary the devil walks about like a raring lion, seeking whom he may devour” (**1Pet 5:8**).

Our Lord said, “He who endures to the end will be saved” (**Mt 10:22**), “He who overcomes shall inherit all things” (**Rev 21:8**). St. Paul said, “Lest, when I have preached to others, I myself should become disqualified” (**1Cor 9:27**), therefore, he also said, “Work out your salvation in fear and trembling” (**Phil 2:12**) and St. Peter exhorts us, “conduct yourselves throughout the time of your sojourning here in fear” (**1Pet 1:17**). The outcome of our life and struggle will be revealed in the last day, “. . . you, who are kept by the power of God through faith for salvation ready to be revealed in the last time” (**1Pet 1:5**). Therefore, our Lord said, “Be faithful until death, and I will give you the crown of life” (**Rev 2:10**).

Since the spiritual struggle and warfare takes up our whole life, therefore salvation is indeed the story of the whole life.

* This lecture is adapted from ‘The Heresy of Salvation in a Moment ’ by H.H. Pope Shenouda III.



“Assuredly, I say to you, wherever this gospel is preached throughout the whole world, what this woman did will also be spoken of as a memorial to her.” (Mk 14:9)

+ **Lecture VI: On the Saints’ Intercession & Veneration** +

In Lecture II of Mariology, we presented, by the grace of God, the Orthodox Concept of intercession. However, we need to highlight the fact that in honoring the saints and angels we do not put them in the place of Lord Jesus Christ or even adjacent to Him. No one except Lord Jesus Christ is able to save man from sin thus when the saints pray for us, it is our salvation that they seek from the Lord. They intercede with Him for our salvation. From the Lord they entreat our salvation — not, however, as if they themselves have the power to save, for the only one who saves is Lord Jesus Christ.

❖ **Biblical Exam les of Intercession:**

- **(Gen 20:1-7)** 9 Abimelech King of Gerar took Sarah to his palace because our father Abraham said that she was his sister. However God rebuked him and ordered him to restore Sarah to her husband and said to him, “...he [Abraham] will pray for you and you shall live” **(Gen 20:7)**.
- **(Job 42:7,8)** God made the prayer of Job the Righteous on behalf of the three friends a condition for their forgiveness.
- **(Gen 18:26-32)** God said to our father Abraham that He would not destroy Sodom “for the sake” of even 10 righteous people. _
- **(Jer 5:1)** It is written that God is ready to pardon Jerusalem for the sake of one righteous person.
- **(Ex 32:7-14)** We read about Moses the Prophet interceding on behalf of the People with God.

❖ Thus we conclude that God Himself encourages and accepts intercession. However, someone may protest and say that the above holy verses are examples of intercession of people who are still alive. Therefore, we shall mention more biblical examples about the intercession of saints who have already departed:

- **(Ex 32:13)** Moses the Prophet is asking God to act for the sake of Abraham, Isaac, and Israel.
- **(1 Kg 11:12,13)** God declares that He will not tear the kingdom away in the days of King Solomon “for the sake” of his father David the Prophet who had already departed.
- **(Jer 15:1)** God, wanting to illustrate how sever His wrath towards the people, said, “Even if Moses and Samuel [who had already departed] stood before Me, My mind would not be favorable toward this people.” — This shows that the principle of intercession does exist.

❖ **God Honors His Saints:**

God honors His saints by giving them extraordinary powers and gifis. For instance we read that the dead bones of Elisha the Prophet raised the dead **(2 Kg 13:21)** and the handkerchiefs or aprons of St. Paul healed the sick and cast out demons (Acts 19:12) while the shadow of St. Peter healed the sick **(Acts, 5:15)**. Therefore, Elijah the Prophet said with confidence, “there shall not be dew nor rain these years, except at my word.” **(1 Kg 17:1)** — Our Lord said, “If anyone serves Me, him My Father will honor.” **(Jn 12:26)**

Thus, since God Himself has honored His saints, and accepted their intercessions, we are not mistaken if we honor them and ask for their prayer, blessings and intercession.

Q1: Do the saints who departed and the angels know what happens on earth?

A1: Our Lord said, “Likewise, I say to you, there is joy in the presence of the angels of God over one sinner who repents.” (**Lk 15:10**) — Thus the angels know and also react to what happens on earth. Moreover, our Lord said that the saints who depart would be like “angels of God in heaven.” (**Mt 22:30**) Therefore we read about the souls of the martyrs that they knew that God had not avenged their blood yet (**Rev 6:10**). Also our father Abraham knew that the rich man had received his good things in his life time and that Lazarus evil things (**Lk 16:25**) he also knew about Moses and the prophets. St. Paul said, “Now I know in part, but then I shall know just as I also am known.” (**1 Cor 13:12**)

Q2: Why are the Orthodox Churches named after saints aren't they God's Churches?

A2: Indeed they are. However, naming the house of God after the saints does not mean that they share God's Glory. For instance, God's temple was called after King Solomon and God's Law was called the “Law of Moses” (**Mal 4:4**) also the inspired Holy Scriptures are God's words yet we read “the words of Jeremiah” (**Jer 1:1**) and “the vision of Isaiah” (**Is 1:1**) — Moreover, we read about the heavenly Jerusalem, “Now the wall of the city had twelve foundations, and on them were the names of the twelve apostles of the Lamb.” (**Rev 21:14**) Also, God called Himself the God of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob (**Ex 3:6; 4:5; Mt 22:32**)

Q3: Is the veneration of the saints' relics border on idolatry?

A3: The holy relics are neither idols nor deities, nor figures of God, and their veneration is not idol worship. For inasmuch as God has glorified them, giving them miraculous power, so too should we venerate them, for this way we honor God, who bestowed His grace on them (**2 Kg 13:21**). — These relics were the temple of the Holy Spirit (**1 Cor 6:19**) and thus we are not honoring the bones themselves, but the divine grace bestowed on them.

❖ A Final Word:

The interaction between the heavenly hosts (saints & angels) and the Church in this world is a practical reality that we experience and thus is not really subject to theological debate and philosophical arguments. Those who deny this reality are the ones who lose the blessings.

* This lecture is adapted from ‘Comparative Theology’ by H.H. Pope Shenouda III.



“The days will come when the bridegroom will be taken away from them, and then they will fast.”

(Mt 9:15)

+ **Lecture VIII: On Fasting** +

Protestants neglect fasting and do not encourage people to fast. They consider fasting a human work and since to them good works do not play any role in salvation; they have not emphasized the importance and the benefits of fasting. It is not uncommon to find people in their fifties or sixties who have not fasted a single day!

❖ **Fasting in the Coptic Church:**

When we fast, we abstain from food and water for a certain period of time that can be determined through the guidance of the father in confession depending on one's spiritual level and health condition. Generally speaking, the abstinence period ends at three o'clock in the afternoon because at this hour [the ninth hour] Lord Jesus Christ died on the cross and saved us. After the end of the abstinence period, we break our fast and only eat vegetarian food, however, since we fast more than half the days of the year, the Church has allowed the congregation to eat fish during certain fasting periods.

In what follows, we shall, by the grace of God, answer some of the frequently asked questions about fasting:

Q1: Our Lord said that fasting should be “in secret” (Mt 6:18) thus shouldn't fasting be left to the individual to decide when to fast?

A1: Our Lord also said that prayer should be “in secret” (Mt 6:6) yet we still go to church on set days and pray as a congregation. Praying in secret does not contradict congregational prayers. Likewise, set seasons for congregational fasting do not contradict the commandment of fasting in secret. Moreover, even if the fasting seasons are set, the depth of each one's fasting and the personal periods of abstinence can remain in secret. There are many biblical examples of congregational fasting:

- The whole congregation fasted together and God accepted their fast (**Esther 4**).
- Everybody in Nineveh fasted together (Jonah 3).
- Congregational fasting is obvious from the words of Joel the Prophet, “Blow the trumpet in Zion, Consecrate a fast, call a sacred assembly; gather the people, sanctify the congregation...” (**Joel 2:15**)
- St. Paul fasted with all the people on the ship (**Acts 27:21**).
- The apostles fasted together (**Acts 13:2,3**).
- The principle of having set dates for fasting has its origins in Holy Scripture, “The fasting of the fourth month, the fast of the fifth, the fast of the seventh, and the fast of the tenth ...” (**Zech 8:19**)

Q2: What are the times of fast in the Coptic Church?

A2: The Coptic Church fasts over half the days of the year:

- The Advent fast that ends with the Holy Nativity feast (43 days in length / fish allowed) Jonah's fast (3 days / no fish allowed) The Holy Great Lent that ends with the Holy Resurrection feast (55 days in length/ no fish allowed) The Apostles fast that ends with the feast of martyrdom of Ss Paul & Peter (length varies/ fish allowed) St. Mary's fast that ends with the feast of the assumption of her body (14 days / fish allowed)
- Every Wednesday & Friday except during the fifty days after the Holy Resurrection (no fish allowed) — commemorates the plotting of the Jews to crucify our Savior on Wednesday and the crucifixion on Friday.

- ❖ During the fasts where fish is allowed, it is allowed only on all days except Wednesday & Friday. Moreover, on Saturday & Sunday there is no period of abstinence from food.

Q3: What is the wisdom behind eating vegetarian food only after the period of abstinence?

A3: The vegetarian food was the diet that God had prepared for Adam and Eve (**Gen 1:29**) they also continued to eat it even after the sin (**Gen 3:18**). God did not allow man to eat meat except after the flood (**Gen 9:3**) and when God saved the Israelites from the bondage of Pharaoh, He offered them the manna (**Num 11:7,8**) - He only gave them meat to eat after they murmured against Him (**Num 11:33**) and with meat He struck them and killed many of them. Thus we conclude that the vegetarian food was the original diet for humans and that it is recommended as a means of asceticism not because other foods are unclean but in order to discipline our bodies.

Q4: Why does the Church allow us to eat fish on certain fasts?

A4: Since the fasting periods are lengthy, the Church has decided to allow her children to eat fish to supplement their diet with a protein source [on certain fasts] if they elect to do so. — We notice that fish was the preferred meal for our Lord Jesus Christ during His Incarnation (**Jn 21:9**).

Q5: Is fasting part of the Christian worship or does it pertain only to the Old Testament?

A5: There are many biblical verses that proves that fasting is indeed expected from every Christian:

- Our Lord said, “. . .do not appear to men to be fasting, but to your Father who is in the secret place; and your Father who sees in secret will reward you openly.” (**Mt 6:18**) — Thus fasting is expected from Christians and there is also a heavenly reward if we fast according to God’s will.
- Our Lord said about His disciples and those who believe their teachings, “The days will come when the bridegroom will be taken away from them, and then they will fast.” (**Mt 9:15**) — an indication that fasting is expected from Christians.
- Our Lord said, “This kind can come out by nothing except by prayer and fasting.” (**Mk 9:29**) — explicit message that without fasting we cannot overcome in our spiritual struggles.
- Our Lord Himself fasted 40 days and 40 nights (**Mt 4:2; Mk 1:12; Lk 4:1**).
- We also read about St. Paul saying “. . .in hunger and thirst, in fastings often . . .” (**2 Cor 11:27**) “in labors, in sleeplessness, in fastings . . .” (**2 Cor 6:5**) and the rest of the apostles fasted as well (**Acts 14:23; 13:3**).
- St. Paul exhorts the married people “give yourselves to fasting and prayer” (**1 Cor 7:5**).

For questions about the spirituality of fasting consult ‘The Spirituality of Fasting’ by H.H. Pope Shenouda III.

* This lecture is adapted from ‘Comparative Theology ’ by H.H. Pope Shenouda III.

WORKS:

Q. Does not mere faith suffice for salvation?

A. No; for the Lord has said, "Not everyone that saith unto Me Lord, Lord, shall enter into the kingdom of heaven; but he that doeth the will of My Father" (S. Matt. vii. 21). The Apostle also said, "Faith without works is dead" (S. James ii. 26). Thus by faith and works the perfection of religion may be attained, but this perfection cannot be reached without the aid of the Grace of God, which is given to all the believers in His religion through the Grace of His Spirit, the duties of the heavenly religion, laying upon them this trust and fulfilling His promise to them of eternal happiness, just as He has given grace to all through His eternal Son Who revealed the Divine faith by His Incarnation.

Q. What is meant by good deeds?

A. Every inward or outward action good and pleasing to God which the Faithful are bound to God which the Faithful are bound by Divine law to perform.

Q. And what is meant by evil deeds?

A. Every inward or outward action opposed to God's Holiness, which the believer is bound by law to avoid.

Q. What aid does the believer require to insure good religious behaviour?

A. Besides knowledge and free will, by which man is bound to be of good religious behavior, he needs always the Grace of God, which helps the willing and the diligent in the way of obedience. Every believer should apply for this grace from above by prayer, in order that he may be enabled through it to behave well according to the religious law.

***The Church of the Virgin Mary & St. Athanasius
Catechism Guide Book III***

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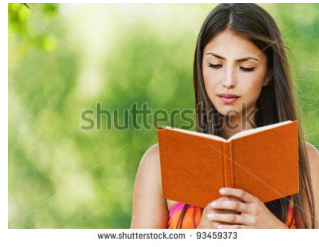
The Coptic Orthodox Liturgy of St. Basil

(This document is not included in the guide book. Please see link below.)

[http://www.copticchurch.net/topics/liturgy/liturgy of st basil.pdf](http://www.copticchurch.net/topics/liturgy/liturgy%20of%20st%20basil.pdf)

- ***(St. Marina Coptic Orthodox Church, LA. USA)***
- ***(St. George Coptic Orthodox Church of Greater Philadelphia)***
- ***Catechism of the Coptic Church vol 1870 by Fr. Filothaus***





Dear Friend:

How are you? I just had to send you this letter to tell you how much I love and care about you. I saw you yesterday as you were walking with your friends. I waited all day, hoping you would talk to Me also.

As evening drew near, I gave you a sunset to close your day and a cool breeze to rest you, and I waited. You never came. Oh yes, it hurt Me, but I still love you because I am your friend.

I saw you fall asleep last night, and I longed to touch your brow, so I spilled moonlight upon your pillow and face. Again I waited, wanting to rush down so we could talk. I have so many gifts for you.

You awakened late and rushed off for the day... My tears were in the rain. Today you looked to sad, so alone. It makes my heart ache because I understand. My friends let Me down and hurt Me many times too, but I love you.

I try to tell you in the quiet green grass; I whisper it in the leaves and trees, I breathe it in the colors of the flowers. I shout it to you in the mountain streams, and give the birds love songs to sing. I clothe you with warm sunshine and perfume the air.

My love for you is deeper than oceans and bigger than the biggest want or need that you have. We will spend eternity together in heaven. I know how hard it is on this earth. I really know because I was there, and I want to help you.

My Father wants to help you too. He's that way, you know. Just call Me, ask Me, talk to Me. It is your decision. I have chosen you, and because of this I will wait.. Because I love you.

Your friend, Jesus